Rishi Sunak & Akshata Murty: Power, Identity & Why Patience Beats Ambition | Nikhil | People by WTF

(0:54 - 1:22)

I'm not going to talk to Akshita like she's Rishi's wife or Narayan Murthy's daughter. Forget Rishi and your dad, where does Akshita's validation come from? From genuinely having impact. How is the journey Rishi from going from being a person who was at Goldman Sachs to becoming the Prime Minister of UK? No, it's a big question.

(1:22 - 1:56)

It's a big question. A lot more young people need to participate in politics. For somebody sitting on the outside, a young guy who wants to be in politics, how hard is it? Is it that one person can actually change stuff? Tell me when we start.

(1:57 - 2:05)

You started? Sure. Okay. Sorry, I wouldn't mind it.

(2:05 - 2:10)

Is it possible to get fresh lime soda? Yeah, of course. If that's doable. Sweet, if that's a go.

(2:11 - 2:17)

Do you want salt in it as well? Actually, just sweet would be good. Just sweet. So I've been in Alibaug the last few days.

(2:17 - 2:19)

I just got back. Yeah. Just now.

(2:20 - 2:27)

Which is, pardon my geography. Which is a 30-minute boat ride from Bombay. Okay.

(2:27 - 2:36)

And that's like a hill station-ish? It's much like Bombay, but no people. Right. It's like the Hamptons.

(2:36 - 2:53)

It's not prettier than Bombay. It's just emptier than Bombay. So you go there for a little bit of... No, we have this thing we are running called Foundry, which is like a residential college for

entrepreneurship.

(2:53 - 2:58)

A three-month course. Okay. So about 20 to 30 people get selected.

(2:59 - 3:03)

So each cohort is 20 to 30? Yeah. Like the Y Combinator, I think. Yeah, very much.

(3:03 - 3:10)

They get a half a million dollars. They get to build the business while they live there in one house for three months. And then mentorship.

(3:11 - 3:18)

Yeah. So I was with the current batch. It's a good place to do it near Bombay because it's empty and nobody lives there.

(3:19 - 3:24)

And did you set it up? Yeah. Yeah. How many batches have you gone through? First batch.

(3:24 - 3:26)

Oh, this is the first. Yeah. First batch.

(3:26 - 3:32)

That's super exciting. Very excited. Is there anything else like that in India? Y Combinator and these guys are not here, right? Yeah.

(3:32 - 3:39)

And this one is very consumer focused. So we're building 20 consumer brands. So one will be a candy company.

(3:40 - 3:42)

One is a toothpaste company. It's like my kind of dream. It's your dream.

(3:42 - 3:49)

We can get into that. But we started Catch My Adventures doing that kind of thing. So one is a candy company.

(3:50 - 3:53)

Yeah. One is a toothpaste company. One just makes jeans.

(3:53 - 4:10)

One makes chocolates of a certain kind. Very interesting. And normally, these things don't necessarily rush into consumer companies, right? So it's nice to have a source of not just capital, but deep passion and expertise for this space.

(4:10 - 4:34)

And in India, when you see the GDP number growing at six to seven percent, a really large component of that is consumer, which is growing at 12, 13 percent. So the Indian consumer is saving less, especially the younger generation, and they're spending more. Also, I would say beginning to borrow more to spend more.

(4:35 - 4:41)

Which was not the case only when I grew up. No, not when I grew up. You can say we grew up at the same time.

(4:42 - 4:48)

We are somewhat contemporaries, but I'll let you run away with the younger person. Probably in the same area as well. Yeah.

(4:48 - 5:00)

Maybe like five minutes away from each other. Yeah. Have you selected the people where they all apply and you just go through? And how many applications did you get? We created an AI quiz, which is about 45 minutes.

(5:01 - 5:15)

A few thousand people cleared it. And then we had a boot camp for the last four days where we went down from 75 people to 25 people, which will be the first cohort. This is so fun.

(5:15 - 5:33)

And the individuals, so say there's a lady with a business plan. Do they then meet potential team members in this cohort? Yeah. So many of them team up and become co-founders.

(5:33 - 5:47)

Right. So the ideas are already there of what could be built. And we help to a large extent in

manufacturing, distribution, marketing, content, packaging, all of that.

(5:47 - 5:59)

Yeah. So the idea is to really expedite the time to market and do it in the three months while they all live in one house. Sounds great.

(5:59 - 6:03)

What's it called? It's called Foundry. Foundry. We'd love to have you guys.

(6:03 - 6:14)

I would love it. If you get her involved, Nikhil, I won't be able to get her back home. You've just described something that is probably her dream.

(6:14 - 6:21)

Something that I've been thinking about myself. Kiran's going to be there for a few days. Oh, so you bring in people to interact.

(6:23 - 6:32)

And have you funded it? If you don't mind me asking, you funded it yourself? Yeah. Fully. And then is it a standard term sheet? Yeah, it's a fairly standard term sheet.

(6:32 - 6:42)

So they all start with that? All 20 of them get about half a million dollars beginning. And then at the end of three months, they need more money. Then we open it up for whoever wants to buy.

(6:42 - 6:53)

At that point, yeah. Do you have a right, but presumably an obligation, to follow on if you want? I think we both have so many questions because it's so exciting. That sounds great.

(6:55 - 7:22)

So presumably you're investing like angel, right? Yeah. So the next step of funding, aside from you, in the consumer space in India, do you find there are sufficient folks who can kind of put that kind of money in? In India, yes, because of the rate of growth in consumption, which is the opposite of the Western world. Interesting.

(7:22 - 7:33)

Like you would find it just as easy to get money for consumer as you would for tech in India.

Amazing. This sounds great.

(7:34 - 7:39)

Sounds really great. Yeah, it should be fun. And you can also film them like that.

(7:39 - 7:45)

We are, we are making it a show. Like seven episodes. What's the average age? 28.

(7:46 - 8:01)

That's actually a bit older than I would have thought. It's funny, we realized that we have some who are really young, like 18 and 19. But we ended up picking a lot of people who were in their late 30s as well.

(8:01 - 8:04)

Okay. Just worked out that way. There was no plan going.

(8:04 - 8:11)

Yeah, no, you just saw who. Yeah. And we're making a TV show because... Yes, that's my thing.

(8:11 - 8:22)

We want to make them heroes before the product hits the market so people buy the product. And Nikhil, you and I know, growing up, who were the heroes of our time, right? Yeah. You had incredible cricket folks.

(8:23 - 8:26)

You had Bollywood. My dad and Jainagar. And my dad.

(8:27 - 8:43)

Much beyond Jainagar. But literally, I think one of the reasons my dad stood out was because he was a man with an idea and a vision and a business plan, really. And so you're saying, let's take that and make heroes out of these men and women.

(8:44 - 8:48)

How cool is that? Like, let's make business cool. I mean, business is cool now. Yeah.

(8:48 - 8:53)

You know, I interviewed your dad a few years ago. Did you? Yeah. Oh, we did? I didn't see that.

(8:53 - 9:02)

It was not on camera. I have so many things to say but we're on camera so I'm not going to say a lot of things. It was not on camera.

(9:03 - 9:15)

It was like a conversation we were having for a Karnataka government thing. I see your mum every time Kiran has a... Correct. Has a good event or a bad event? She's part of the posse.

(9:15 - 9:25)

Yeah. The last time I met your mum, we were in a... Where were we? No, this was unfortunately when Kiran's husband had passed away. Yeah, John.

(9:26 - 9:33)

2022. We were at the crematorium. And there was a poster of a god on the ceiling.

(9:33 - 9:43)

So I was looking at it and she came up to me and she's like, Nikhil, do you know what that is? It was the god who's in charge of... Yama. Yama. Yama Raj.

(9:43 - 9:48)

No, he's a god of crematoriums. Oh, right. Who's in charge of... Very specific.

(9:49 - 9:58)

Very specific. So she sat me down and told me the story for like 10 minutes. This is his job, you know, in Haridwar where there are many fires at the same time.

(9:58 - 10:08)

He's the guy in charge of keeping the place running and moving one soul from here to there. Very interesting story. That is classic, classic your mum.

(10:09 - 10:21)

Not at the kind of macro level of gods, it's... But she... I'm very specific. She is so passionate about storytelling. Yeah.

(10:21 - 10:45)

And then she deploys that skill, whether she's writing for kids, whether she's now, you know,

she's a member of parliament by the Rajya Sabha, whether she... I think even when she was an engineer, she somehow was able to put things together to have a narrative that appealed to people. So I think really interesting. I mean, you've seen that all the time.

(10:45 - 11:11)

It is a great gift in life. I think I look at it and marvel that her ability to tell a story about anything in any context is a superpower because it's by far and away the most powerful way to communicate. And she somehow has in her head just stories for everything, for every age group, every topic, there'll be something.

(11:11 - 11:30)

And in politics, I feel like you've realized how important it is. I think even in business, in everything, if you can communicate through storytelling, it's a... Did you have to learn to storytell? Yeah. It's something I've learned because of you and your mum.

(11:32 - 11:56)

It doesn't come as naturally to me. I approach things a bit more practically, a bit more analytically, which is fine, but it's not as effective for communicating, certainly politically, but I think in general. But then, obviously, you are more like your mum, right? Her instinctive way to explain something is with a story.

(11:56 - 12:02)

And I see how she does it with the kids. It's just how you see the world. But your mum isn't... You see the world in narratives.

(12:02 - 12:12)

You are people-centric. You put ideas together. And naturally, there's a kind of beginning, middle, and end to it.

(12:12 - 12:27)

But you don't consciously think about it, obviously. I agree with her. For a guy who looks like me, brown-skinned, to become the Prime Minister of England, you have to be good at storytelling.

(12:29 - 12:33)

Yeah. That's nice of you to say. That's nice of you to say.

(12:34 - 12:46)

I... At your age. At my age. Look, I think... Obviously, you have to be able to communicate

reasonably well in politics.

(12:47 - 13:03)

I think different times require different types of communication than the pandemic struck. And so that was my introduction to the country. So I was doing... A, I was doing something that I was very comfortable in, which was economic policy.

(13:04 - 13:29)

But that time, I think, was atypical, Nikhil, because... I don't know what it was like here, but in the UK, and similar in the US and other places, everyone just watched the government press conference every evening. Because people couldn't leave their homes, everyone was at home, and everyone was worried. And so people, in a way that they haven't done for decades, most of the country just sat down at five or six o'clock or whatever time.

(13:29 - 13:41)

I think it was five o'clock we did these things. And then there would be a different minister every day on the TV talking to the country. And that was my introduction to the country.

(13:41 - 14:05)

And it suited me, because you didn't need to be a brilliant storyteller for what people wanted. What they wanted was... A clear communicator. They wanted someone who could explain things clearly, provide reassurance, and then do these things that would help them and explain what we were doing economically, how it was going to benefit them, with a hopefully reassuring tone.

(14:05 - 14:33)

And you had this... You had a captive audience who were hungry for that information. And so it probably suited my style. And then actually that... Once politics gets back to normal, and no one is tuning in for half an hour, with a slightly more sympathetic bias as they're listening to you, that's when, actually, if you're able to communicate with storytelling, it would have served me better, actually.

(14:34 - 14:38)

I watched a lot of your interviews. There aren't many. I think you guys have done very few interviews.

(14:39 - 14:43)

You mean together, or...? Together, there are one or two. There's very few. The Stanford one.

(14:43 - 14:46)

Yes, we've done the Stanford speech. And that's it. One about maths.

(14:46 - 14:50)

And yes. That's the newer thing for us to do together, is this charity. Yeah.

(14:51 - 15:03)

So you've seen a few of them. But I've never seen you speak about life truly, and not in a manner that you are doing today. I hear about Akshita's parents a lot, never about yours.

(15:04 - 15:12)

They're awesome. Yeah. In fact, I went through a period where I said to Rishi, I'm not sure if I want to marry you or not, but then I don't want to lose your parents.

(15:12 - 15:22)

The best way is to... And they certainly spend more time. My parents spend more time talking to you than they do to me. But they're genuinely amazing.

(15:22 - 15:45)

I'll give my two cents, because I obviously didn't grow up with them. And you were saying, you know, Rishi, for someone who looks like me, I would say so much of that is down to them. Because they raised, all three of you, by the way, with incredible values.

(15:45 - 16:05)

And you should talk about what those values are, but incredible values. And they're the living embodiment of those values. And so, I feel very lucky that my children, on the one hand, of course, I'm so proud of my parents and everything that they stand for, not achieve, but what they stand for.

(16:06 - 16:18)

That's really important. But they have another set of grandparents. And I got to know a lot more about your parents' kind of journey when, I think there was that book that came out on you by Mike Lashcroft.

(16:19 - 16:27)

I can't remember the name. When you were chancellor. And so I was, Rishi didn't have time, so I was doing some of the digging into their journeys.

(16:28 - 16:34)

And it's incredible. Where are they now? What do they do? They still live in Southampton, where I was born. They are retired.

(16:35 - 16:49)

They're spending time with their, well, they keep busy, but they spend time with their grandkids when they can. They just, they just, our two girls actually were in Bangalore this week with Akshayla's mum and dad for half term. And then they just got back.

(16:50 - 16:58)

But my parents came to surprise them at the airport. So they've been having a nice time, the four of them over the weekend. No, so they still live in the town where I was born.

(16:58 - 17:05)

And grew up. My dad was a GP, family doctor. My mum was a pharmacist.

(17:07 - 17:19)

And, you know, I've spoken about this and they were very much my inspiration for wanting to go into politics. You might think that's a bit odd given that they're medical. But I worked for them.

(17:20 - 17:31)

And I worked mainly for my mum in the shop in the back. And so I'd be doing, making up all the medicines and cleaning things. I'd do all the accounts as well and the bookkeeping.

(17:31 - 17:43)

And that got me into business side of things. and then I would deliver the medicines. So I'd be on my bike and then in the evenings you'd go around and then I'd drop them off for the patients that couldn't come in and pick them up.

(17:43 - 17:52)

And then later on, you know, I learned to drive. I did it that way. But the, I was really struck because they'd been doing the same thing in the same place 30 years.

(17:52 - 18:07)

And the surgery and the pharmacy were nearby each other. So they had lots of similar patients overlapping. And I would, I was struck because you'd go to the door and you'd hand the thing and they'd say, oh, are you Mrs. Sunak's son? Or are you Dr. Sunak's son? And I'd say yes.

(18:07 - 18:21)

And then they would proceed to tell me some lovely story about my mum and dad. They'd say, oh, it would invariably be something that either or both of them had done to them or their parents or their grandparents or their kids. And I, you just got this repeatedly.

(18:22 - 18:45)

And the same, the same thing would happen if we were out at the weekend or shopping. And I came to realise that it was possible for just one person or two people as individuals to have this quite strong impact in their community in a way that you could touch so many people's lives and make a difference to them. And I thought that was inspiring.

(18:45 - 18:54)

And so that was my motivation for becoming a politician. Because in the UK, our districts, our constituencies are small. And it's very retail.

(18:54 - 19:04)

So you are, even when you're prime minister, you're still doing that. You're conducting, they're still called surgeries. You have a surgery as an MP.

(19:04 - 19:10)

People come and see you with their problems. You help them. And you're out, embedded in your local community.

(19:10 - 19:19)

And I get a lot of fulfilment from that. And actually, one of the things, having left Downing Street, that I get to do more of is that aspect of the job, having stayed as an MP. That's in North Yorkshire.

(19:19 - 19:22)

That's why our home is in North Yorkshire. I Googled it. It looks really pretty.

(19:23 - 19:25)

It's very pretty. It's very green. Very green.

(19:25 - 19:34)

Yeah, you'd like it. Actually, Ciarán also, sadly John passed away, but that was on their list. Because it's, depending on which train you take, it's on the way to Scotland.

(19:34 - 19:41)

Yeah, it's on the way up to Scotland. It's a fiercely independent people in Yorkshire. And it's, but it's stunning rural England.

(19:41 - 19:48)

I represent more sheep than people. So I've become very familiar with all things farming related. And there's two national parks.

(19:48 - 19:58)

And it's beautiful. But yeah, so that's the thing I got from them was just through working with them and seeing how they made a difference. That was my inspiration.

(19:59 - 20:05)

So obviously I disappointed them by not becoming a doctor. But... I think you did fine. I did, it's okay.

(20:05 - 20:08)

It's okay. There's always time now. It worked out okay.

(20:09 - 20:14)

It worked out okay. Yeah. But it was a definite adjustment for them.

(20:14 - 20:27)

Yeah? Yeah, well, because I was studying economics and philosophy and they didn't... And they're like, they understand science. We kind of... We understand law. They just... Yeah, because they thought I might become a lawyer.

(20:27 - 20:40)

So they understood that. Even in those days, they were kind of like, what degree, what subject you're studying? What degree does that mean? What job does that mean? Right? It was... And I had to explain, it's okay, it's a good degree. It's good A-levels.

(20:40 - 20:57)

I'll be able to get a job and it would be fine. But the other thing with them, and that's actually in spite of the superficial differences between our families, the thing that united them was, for my parents, it was all about education. Right.

(20:57 - 21:13)

So for them, they worked and they worked and they worked and they did extra jobs and everything else and they worked seven days a week. And all of that was so that we could go to great schools. Their view was that they just threw everything into that, sacrificed everything for that.

(21:13 - 21:16)

It's actually a very Indian thing. It's a very Indian thing. Correct.

(21:16 - 21:21)

Exactly that. It's a very Indian thing. My parents did exactly that.

(21:21 - 21:31)

And I think the Indian community as a whole, we value education. As the passport, as a way for a better life. Right.

(21:32 - 21:45)

But I was really lucky because I went to great schools as a result of that. And I had help along the way, as did my brother and sister. But that was kind of drilled into us that this is important.

(21:46 - 22:17)

Do you think it still works though? If you were to argue that the Indian education system, which is very marks dependent and rank dependent, is teaching us to be conformist in a world that is no longer avoiding conformity? So, first of all... Go on. I can imagine we'll have... So I studied in India till I was 18. And then I... The truth is, Nikhil, at 16, both my parents are engineers.

(22:19 - 22:35)

Even in 96, I knew at 16, I knew that they were special and amazing. And I thought a lot of it was down to them being engineers. Right? Far from the point.

(22:35 - 22:46)

But I knew I didn't want to be an engineer. And so then, well, what are my options? I didn't want to be a doctor. And so I knew I wanted to read and write and storytell.

(22:47 - 22:57)

And I loved history. But I also loved the social sciences, economics. And so I ended up going to the US and I have a liberal arts degree.

(22:58 - 23:23)

But I think the Indian education system, from when I know it, is a numbers game. Because it puts you on a path where you end up... If you know what you're doing, it's great. But if you don't know what you want to do, I'm not so sure that works.

(23:23 - 23:35)

But I think it's changing. And now with things like technology, I think we're able to be more open-minded about what that education system should be. But Nikhil, to your point, it's not just India.

(23:35 - 23:52)

Because of AI, every country is having to think about its education system and reimagine it for this world. What is worth studying? What are the right skills to teach young people? And we think about it. We have two daughters who are about to grow up into this world.

(23:52 - 24:10)

And I think the one thing we know is it's actually very hard to say with certainty. I'm lucky to spend time with the people developing this technology, people thinking about it. I think there's just an incredible amount of uncertainty about exactly how this is all going to work out.

(24:10 - 24:25)

Would you send your daughters to an engineering college today? I think, you know, would I send them to an engineering college? Look, they're so young. If that's what they were passionate about. I'm not as familiar with Indian education system versus UK or US.

(24:25 - 24:46)

And that's the point I was trying to make, Nikhil. I thought if you're a fairly good student, you have to be a doctor or an engineer. And I didn't want to be either of those, right? But they're not old enough yet where I'm sitting there going, if they were engineers, should they do more electrical engineering because hardware is more important than computer science or something.

(24:47 - 25:03)

I'm not at that level with them. And neither of us are. But I think some things that are starting to become clearer about this AI world is you can almost break down, I think about it, you can break down most jobs into a set of tasks.

(25:04 - 25:16)

All of our jobs are a set of tasks. And we've talked about this, right? And there's bits that AI is

clearly going to be very good at. And then there's bits that it probably won't be.

(25:16 - 25:31)

And you just need to make sure that your education is not so narrow that it gives you the breadth, these horizontal skills. And it's things like critical thinking. It's kind of knowing what question to ask the model.

(25:31 - 25:46)

The model will always have more knowledge than you, but you need to know how to get the best out of it. And that comes from critical thinking, reasoning, judgment, being able to evaluate the answer that comes back and then go back. That is a set of skills.

(25:46 - 26:05)

I mean, liberal arts education in the US is one that focuses on that type of horizontal thinking. So that to me, I think, is as our kids are thinking, whether it's engineering or economics or whatever, having some breadth that allows you to do that. Because just developing deep knowledge about one thing, which you do need in life.

(26:05 - 26:18)

I'm a big believer you need to become a subject expert and go deep. But from a skills capability, you just need to have that breadth. And I think the other thing is, and actually, this is when we were at Stanford together.

(26:19 - 26:30)

We had this, remember, I made the mistake, in what in hindsight, made a mistake, right? And you told me this at the time. Yeah. About, you know, when we were doing all the class selection.

(26:30 - 26:39)

Yes. And I, at that age, you're in your 20s. I was drawn more to the harder things that I enjoyed.

(26:40 - 27:06)

Investing, extra finance, that type of thing, right? And I liked those classes and I thought they were going to be very relevant to me. And you were right, right? And you were pushing me and you did more of all the things like interpersonal dynamics, organizational behavior, understanding humans and behavior and understanding people. Skills and people-centric focus, essentially.

(27:07 - 27:16)

So I think Stanford's great because they don't allow you to major as such. Like you don't do a

finance MBA or a marketing. And so you invariably have to take a broad mix.

(27:17 - 27:44)

But I think we came, because of our relationship, we were able to get each other to try the other thing, right? And if I look back, I mean, you were right on that. And the thing is, at that age, I think you probably undervalue how important those things are. And then the thing is, if you want to end up in life in a leadership position, then those things are more valuable, right? Actually, you will always be able to learn how to do the finance and the accounting.

(27:45 - 27:56)

And actually the AI will be able to do it for you. But, you know, figuring, you know, why something didn't work is because of the people aspect of it. It's how you set up the team.

(27:56 - 28:20)

Why is that person not motivated? What's your approach to risk? It won't be because of, like, someone didn't get the DCF right, or whatever it is. Also now. Yeah, and that's why with our kids, again, when they're thinking about all those things, it's where do you, whether it's an undergrad grad or in life, where do you pick up that set of skills? And actually educational institutions are the right place to do it.

(28:20 - 28:31)

And I remember you made this point to me because I wasn't British and reserved and you were more comfortable being vulnerable. Risk-taking. Yeah, but you were more comfortable being emotionally vulnerable with other people.

(28:31 - 28:59)

And that is the place to do it. Because if you're trying to understand, well, how do you give feedback, which is a critical, if you're trying to build a team, run a team in any context, being able to give feedback and manage people is so critical. And actually trying to figure that out in a low-risk, trusted environment at, say, business school is much better than trying to figure it out on the job when you're 40 and running it.

(28:59 - 29:40)

with the foundry in a way, right? You're saying guys and gals come together and build something you're passionate about, but do that in this intense way. And frankly, it is more low risk than if they had to go out in the real world and do it themselves. Because I think everything comes down to people in the end, right? So understanding people in a better way, which again, I think what I'd say, you know, as kids, as an engineer, but it's these other things I'd want to make sure one way

or another, from school, from college, from whatever else, they're building those skill sets.

(29:41 - 29:59)

Because I think whatever happens with AI, those will be more and more valuable over time. I always say to Rishi, I'm so intrigued. And frankly, more convinced than ever that in the world of AI, let's figure out, let's lean into being more human.

(29:59 - 30:11)

And what does it mean to be more human? We can have a conversation around that. But I think to me, those qualities are compassion. It becomes more important, not less important.

(30:12 - 30:24)

Compassion and intuition and things like that. Now, you can tell me whether AI can learn all of that, maybe in time, AGI, et cetera. But let's lean into those human skills.

(30:26 - 30:42)

And those are not, and I think schools are changing, schools, because I now have been, in one shape or form, I have been a part of the Indian education system, the US education system, and the British education system. Through the kids, yeah. Through the kids.

(30:43 - 31:03)

And in all of these places, I see it is changing, Nikhil. It's not like when I was growing up, right? But is it changing fast enough? That's a question. Yeah, I think that is the key, right? And I think probably because, same with you, we're closer to the technology development.

(31:03 - 31:13)

So we see what's happening there. And the government always moves slower than that, even at the best of times. Changing whole systems, like an education system, takes time.

(31:13 - 31:38)

My general, and I was saying this last week at AI Summit, what political leaders can't afford to do is treat AI like tomorrow's problem. It is an action this day issue. And there probably is not much, I don't think you see a huge amount of debate and discussion about changing the education system.

(31:39 - 31:51)

So in a way, we are saying being a generalist is better than being an expert. Yeah, I mean, so interesting. Because I would think that you would say, no, you need to build deep skills in a

couple of things.

(31:52 - 31:57)

I think this is, yeah. So we might not say the same thing. I don't know.

(31:57 - 32:16)

And I would use a different word for generalist. I'd say breadth. I think the set of what, their horizontal skills, you need those, which are not domain specific, right? The critical reasoning, thinking, judgment, all those human centric skills that we just talked about, empathy, feedback, dispute regulation.

(32:17 - 32:27)

Yeah, exactly. Dispute negotiation. All those human centric skills and a set of cognitive, but horizontal cognitive skills like critical reasoning.

(32:27 - 32:55)

So that's where you need what I call horizontal skills, which aren't domain specific. But I don't think it's old fashioned, but I still think, if you want to do something well, you have to have deep knowledge, master it. And you want to do something well, you need to commit time and effort to being someone who stands out on it.

(32:55 - 33:08)

Now, look, that is easier now. Well, sorry. What's easier now is for many more people to reach a high knowledge level because of AI, right? So it's harder to stand out for that, but you can't not have that.

(33:08 - 33:33)

That's my view. Now, that might be a bit of an old fashioned view, but I tend to think, if you're talking to someone who's pitching you for one of your companies, right? And then there's Foundry and they'd say, okay, they've got an idea for a confectionery business. If they don't know the confectionery market in India inside out, I think it would be, I mean, I don't know.

(33:33 - 33:57)

I mean, I would find that odd, right? But I would expect them to know more about the confectionery market than anyone else that I speak to. And my thing is, you only build deep knowledge in something, I think, if you're passionate about it. And so when I think of that in the context of entrepreneurship, take the confectioner business, this person probably, for a number of reasons, deeply cares about that space.

(33:58 - 34:49)

And that's when innovation happens, I think, right? So deep knowledge combined with passion, combined with this breadth of skills that we've talked about, is, I think, incredibly interesting. But to your point, and this is on college, right? So if one of our kids was doing a degree or they're choosing a degree, whatever it is, engineering, English, economics, if all they did for the three, four years was just study that subject without building those broad capabilities, then that would be, I think, a problem, right? They would not be set up to succeed in this world. Now, you can build those capabilities through the subject, you can do it as a standalone class.

(34:49 - 35:11)

But if all you did is just study the pure subject and you're the expert on this industrial economics over here and that macroeconomics over there and Dario talking about Cournot equilibriums took me back to my industrial economics classes. That is not sufficient. That is absolutely not sufficient if you haven't left at the same time with that other horizontal.

(35:11 - 35:26)

I think that comes back to what makes us more human. Are you guys like this at home? Are we? We... What does like this mean? I don't know. What is the this? Again, again, because we're on camera.

(35:26 - 35:36)

What is the this? Having interesting conversations? Having interesting conversations, you mean? You finish each other's lines off. Oh. I think we are.

(35:37 - 35:41)

I really do. But underneath you don't agree. Not always.

(35:41 - 35:46)

Oh, we've... Not always. Oh, yeah. Good way to put it.

(35:46 - 35:58)

So I think our destination is always the same. Which is? So... Depends on the situation. Yes, like we end up arriving at the same decision, say.

(35:59 - 36:02)

For the most part. For the most part. Or at least in all the big stuff, no? Yeah.

(36:04 - 36:17)

But I think our journeys... We don't start... Yeah, and we don't start from... We don't often start... I think we probably rarely start from the same place. Oh, I was just going to say, our approaches are quite different. Yeah, exactly.

(36:17 - 36:30)

Right? So, for example, if there's something to do with our children, we'll kind of know how we... We know, in fact, what the answer is. Oh, we know what we're solving for. What we're solving for.

(36:30 - 36:35)

That's right. But then... I will do it... The way you will come at it and the way I will come at it... Exactly. Approach.

(36:36 - 36:38)

Yeah, approach. Right. Starting point will be different.

(36:38 - 36:49)

How is it different? You go and then I'll go. Well, I will probably come at it from a more analytical, more practical... Process-oriented. Process-oriented.

(36:50 - 36:59)

Even in this interview, he's giving me the evil eye when I'm, like, a bit all over the place. And he's like, no, that wasn't the question. I didn't catch it.

(36:59 - 37:07)

No, no. I know the evil eye. Can you show us? A subtle evil eye.

(37:09 - 37:21)

I didn't think I was doing that. Only violently. And then you will come at it... And I will come at it with heart, with passion, like, quite risk-taking.

(37:21 - 37:25)

And more intuitive. And, yeah, heart, intuitive. And less structured.

(37:26 - 37:38)

And much less structured. And less practical. Yeah, and I will be... So, although we're solving for

the same thing, you know, what's best for our kid or what should we do in X or whatever it is... Well, I mean, let's talk about something, right? Like, going into politics.

(37:39 - 37:53)

Rishi, you didn't grow up thinking you would want to go into politics. But when he first talked to me about it, I'm like, great. You can make a real impact and solve all these challenges and Rishi just has a more structured approach to that.

(37:54 - 38:24)

And I thought that was really... But we... On all those things... So we'll... Anyway, we talk about... So we talk... Your point is, so we talk a lot and then it will probably at some point... You know, we're better at... Now. What are you saying in Leer Up? The hand gestures. It might do a bit of that, right? If it's a particularly big thing and we've come at it differently, then there'll be a bit of that.

(38:24 - 38:38)

Go away. Then we'll come back at it and... And as you say, on all the big things, we... We have the same... We end up being very happy, I think, having been through the process. And we have enough trust now.

(38:38 - 38:52)

I mean, you know, how long we've been married. 16, whatever years. We have enough trust that the process is... Even if it's a bit fraught during, we trust the process, right? We trust the process.

(38:52 - 39:24)

And we trust each other. So I think it's... We know that the other person genuinely believes in the same things. So to me, when I say that, I think values, right? And I think those values we share so many, which are around having a great deal of integrity, working hard, being curious about the world around you, and having compassion, I think.

(39:24 - 39:32)

And respecting everybody. Great respect and compassion, yeah. Where did the values come from? I think from our parents.

(39:32 - 39:50)

Parents, yeah. And that was the bit that... As the superficial differences, but I remember when they met that... At your parents' home? Yeah, where you... So our parents first met, which I was stressed about. I was not nervous.

(39:50 - 39:57)

But it was fine. She left me to deal with it. And it was stressful because it wasn't very... She knew both sets.

(39:57 - 40:06)

I knew both sets. When they met, her parents came with her uncle to my parents' house in Southampton. And I was there.

(40:06 - 40:21)

My brother was there. And it was genuinely stressful because they were so different on the surface. But it ended up being... It ended up being really positive.

(40:22 - 40:33)

And that was the thing that your parents had said to me. They said we were apprehensive because we just didn't know whether they would have the same values to us. They're different.

(40:34 - 40:54)

But actually, how... Their approach to life. The things that they value, the things that are important to them, how they've raised you, being in your house. Education being one of them, right? So are values more nurture than nature? You were not born with them? Are values more nurture than nature? Yeah.

(40:54 - 40:58)

I mean, yeah. I think they are. I mean, I say that.

(40:59 - 41:04)

Yeah, I think they are. Yeah. Yeah.

(41:05 - 41:09)

I think so. I was talking to my therapist. I was speaking with my therapist recently.

(41:10 - 41:15)

I'm going to... Yeah, please, go. I'm just assuming this is not for display. So, yeah.

(41:15 - 41:19)

It's not good because I'm not. It's stuck in right now. Mushi is so ridiculous.

(41:20 - 41:29)

I'm just sitting there and I didn't want to... polite and whatnot. He does this in every... Anytime there is... This is huge. There's anything we've done together.

(41:29 - 41:42)

Oh, that's it. We had this... We had a great meeting with another international leader and his spouse. And they had catered afternoon tea, which was very nice.

(41:43 - 41:54)

And we were all... Rightly, you meet them for the first time. You're trying to make sense of each other, making sure that they're comfortable. But there were all these cakes.

(41:54 - 42:05)

And then halfway through it, Rishi's like, well, I'm going to start on the cakes. And it actually was great because no one else was touching any of the food. It was a genuine kind of... We're looking for an icebreaker.

(42:05 - 42:22)

And Rishi just went straight in for the food. So... How was the journey, Rishi, from... Going from being the... person who was at Goldman Sachs to becoming the prime minister of UK? I know it's a big question. It's a big question.

(42:22 - 42:48)

Yeah. Well, I think the first thing to say, it was the... journey that I had imagined even if it happened far faster than I would have imagined. Because I... I'm one of these people who thinks if... If you want to go into politics, you are far better off having done something first.

(42:49 - 43:04)

That's my view. And I think that because... A, you bring a set of skills and experience about something else into the political arena, which is just a good thing. And you have that knowledge, which you can contribute.

(43:06 - 43:13)

But also... And an understanding of the real world. Yeah. I think... Actually, you're saying what I think I'm about to say.

(43:13 - 43:17)

I'm sorry. No, I think it's the same thing. Completing each other's sentences.

(43:18 - 43:30)

No, which is... It's a slightly different mindset to how you approach things. Because if you spent your entire life in politics, you tend to see everything with a political lens. You see the politics in every situation or every problem.

(43:30 - 43:51)

Whereas if you've done something else first and you've just had a normal experience in business, teaching, medicine, whatever it is, armed forces, you come into politics, you don't see the life through a political prism. And I think that is better. So for those reasons, I think doing something else first is the right way to do it.

(43:51 - 44:00)

Certainly, that's what I wanted to do. So in that sense, the career path was one that I had broadly thought about. Obviously, it happened a lot quicker.

(44:00 - 44:35)

And I think the other thing which was important to me, which we talked about a lot at Stanford, was financial independence and financial security was important to me as a precondition to going into public service. Doesn't politics afford that? Sorry? Politics gives you financial security as well, right? I mean, why do you say that? Aren't British politicians paid well? They are paid well by average wage standards. So there's a body that sets politicians' wages relative to a set of professional classes.

(44:36 - 44:52)

So if you look at what the average person in the UK owns, politicians are paid considerably more than that. But for the financial security that I wanted, everyone has their own view, right? For somebody who went to Stanford, probably not from that benchmark. Yeah.

(44:52 - 45:22)

So there was a degree of financial security that I wanted, which was not just to be able to live my life, but to make sure my family were okay, that our kids would be able to have flexibility, that the person that I met would be able to have flexibility. So I kind of came into it wanting to be able to give my kids, my family the choice, actually, to not have to maybe do what I did. I mean, I was lucky.

(45:22 - 45:28)

I liked something. I was passionate about something, to your point. I happen to be passionate about something which is also well-rewarded financially.

(45:28 - 45:43)

But it was very important to me to have that financial independence. Bringing this other set of experience and skills into politics and government was important. So in that sense, the journey happened as I would have wanted it to.

(45:44 - 46:23)

I think what was different about it was the speed. Right. The speed in which it happened, which if I look back and I kind of think, what do I think differently about the world now than I used to at the start of that journey? I used to think speed was the most important thing.

(46:23 - 46:43)

And I've come to appreciate that patience is almost a bigger competitive advantage. And I think when you're that age, Nikhil, I'm sure your resume would... I am that age. No, now I would say.

(46:44 - 47:00)

But I think when you're in your 20s, I think you're constantly thinking about, I've got to get to this point, this point, the next thing. And the list, you know, 30 under 30, young rising stars, 40 under 40 list. And you are focused on getting to the next thing.

(47:01 - 47:06)

And if I don't do this by this point, then the window is gone. And I was very much like that. Then I'm not going to be successful.

(47:06 - 47:20)

I'm not going to be successful. And I think that given, and it might be a strange thing for someone who's had my career path to say, right, you end up being the youngest prime minister in 200 years. And in one sense, that's incredible.

(47:20 - 47:52)

But in another sense, as I say, patience is its own competitive advantage because, you know, there is some times when actually it's worse to arrive too early than it is to arrive too late to something. And it's very much not the view of people, entrepreneurs building companies. But certainly from my experience, there's some things that you reach the position, but you then want to be able to be at your best when you have that position or that role, whatever it might be.

(47:53 - 48:04)

And sometimes that comes with experience and making sure that you have the experience and the judgment to make good decisions when you're in that role. Right. Is it also rate of growth that keeps you happy? For me, yes.

(48:05 - 48:30)

So now what happens after having... After you've done this thing? Yeah. We've had lots of incredibly interesting discussions. I think probably the slightly discomforting thing for me, which actually has helped me get more comfortable with, is for the first time in my life, I don't know what the next thing is.

(48:30 - 48:41)

What to work to work. I'm not working towards a specific thing. Will the high ever be the same? I mean, you were at the pinnacle of validation and importance in society.

(48:42 - 49:13)

I don't think any amount of money will get you there. So what is the high that makes you feel like relatively higher than the previous high? So for me, and I think the same for you, or you're seeing that more now, having this somewhat of a blank canvas is exciting because I love trying out different things. I love, you know, we were talking earlier about risk taking, etc.

(49:13 - 50:03)

Not taking risk for the sake of a risk, but having a blank canvas or some people might say starting over again, right? That's quite exciting because also we have had, both of us, what feels like, because we've been together for now 20 years, these incredibly meaningful, just incredible experiences. So we have a blank canvas, but I would like to think we have wisdom with it and we're lucky we are able to do things that interest us, that fuel our passions. So I would say that's the first thing.

(50:03 - 50:20)

I don't know if that's a high or not, but it's exciting to have that blank canvas. And we're starting to lay colour on it in our own way, in ways that are deeply meaningful to us. So not just doing it to tick a box, right? Not doing it because we have to get to the next milestone.

(50:20 - 50:29)

We don't even know what the next milestone is. It's liberating. Yeah, I think it is in a way liberating.

(50:30 - 50:44)

So I'm 45. We're 45. God willing, I've got more, we've got more working years ahead of us than I've got behind us.

(50:45 - 51:11)

And that, when you think of it like that, I can't live day to day thinking that the most important thing I've done has already happened and nothing else I do in life will give me the same fulfilment or purpose. High is the word you use. A, I don't believe that, and it would be a hard way to live if you did.

(51:11 - 51:42)

And the liberating thing, as I actually said, if there's someone who's always been on this track and it's like, okay, I need to get into this university and then that degree and then that internship and that job and that MP or that business school and that MP and then let's get into the cabinet and that job, et cetera. This blank canvas thing is entrepreneurial, right? And there's a, you know that better than most, right? There's a fulfilment that comes from building something with a blank, starting with a blank canvas, as I actually said. So that's what we're now doing.

(51:43 - 52:27)

And as you said, it's exciting because you get to start this second chapter, second half of your professional life with all these incredible experiences and skills that you've built up, which you didn't have on that journey. And that's what I was saying before, whereas before it was like rush, rush, rush, rush, rush. It felt, I'm not putting words in your mouth, but I think when you're 18, 22, starting your first job, et cetera, I think it can sometimes feel theoretical way, you know in your head, do I have to do this job, this degree to get this job, to get to this place? Whereas now we don't just rely on kind of established frameworks.

(52:27 - 53:11)

We're able to deep dive into what I will call wisdom, right? We are able to build on those incredible frameworks, which are given to you by education, your values, your career experiences, your professional experiences, but also just having had the vast range of meaningful experiences and you're only 45. And you learn from them, right? And you learn from it. All the failures you've had, all the things that you've got wrong and reflected on and the things that you've got right and understanding what you're good at and why you get them right.

(53:12 - 53:30)

I have to believe that roughly, you know, works 20 something years, will have 20 something years left to work and I should be far better set up for success over this next 20 than I was over the last

20. But it depends on how you define success, I guess. Yes, yeah.

(53:30 - 53:50)

But if you're defining success by one particular job or position, then maybe, but I don't think either of us think about success like that. So that maybe is... This is very personal to me. A lot of people, like last night, a bunch of kids were asking me, why don't you become a politician? And I've never thought of it.

(53:50 - 54:26)

I don't have any plan or any inclination whatsoever. But I really want to know how does it feel like to go from working in a corporation to becoming the prime minister? How does the attention feel? How does the criticism feel? How does the responsibility feel? Responsibility, yeah. So, you know, for someone who's entering into politics, you know, like I get asked a similar question.

(54:26 - 54:43)

You know, for young people who are thinking about politics, you know, I say to them, you need to be resilient. You need to be patient. And you need to be motivated by public service more than ambition.

(54:43 - 54:51)

At some level. So those are the, I think, the things that you need to make sure that you have. I was under that.

(54:51 - 55:10)

The day you figured you're becoming prime minister, did you sit at home and you're like, this happened? I didn't have time. Nikhil, I, yeah. It has to be a big thing, right? Yeah, you know what? For me, the circumstances in which I became prime minister, it was so sudden.

(55:11 - 55:19)

I didn't have time to do much of that. We were in different places that weekend. Yeah, I was in Yorkshire.

(55:19 - 55:30)

I was in London. I was one minute, I was with our two kids at TGI Fridays and bowling. I just lost a quite bruising leadership election to Liz Trust.

(55:31 - 55:49)

And I was emotionally starting to look forward to this next chapter of my life, spending time with

the kids, thinking about what we were going to do next. And so I physically and emotionally was in a completely different place. And then all of a sudden this thing happened that I was not prepared.

(55:49 - 55:56)

Thinking actively about. Actively, emotionally, or practically. And it happened just so quickly.

(55:57 - 56:10)

And so you didn't have time. And then, you know, it was a battlefield promotion, right? And there was a huge number of things that I had to deal with immediately. So I didn't really get to have that type of moment.

(56:11 - 56:16)

I think we had one call with your parents. Yeah. So it was Rishi's mother's 70th birthday that day.

(56:16 - 56:21)

It was our youngest daughter's 10th birthday. And it was also Diwali. Throughout all those days that it was happening, yeah.

(56:21 - 56:26)

Yeah. And so we had one phone call with your parents. And that was the point of it, I think.

(56:27 - 56:48)

Actually, the moment it kind of first properly hit me, because the first few days there was so much to do. I forget whether it was five days, four days, a week later, because I became prime minister around Diwali. And so there was a Downing Street Diwali reception a few days after I became prime minister.

(56:48 - 57:11)

And it was at that moment, you know, I was doing that. And obviously, in particular, the significance of being first British Asian, first Hindu prime minister of the UK, it being Diwali, everyone there was very aware of that, and obviously expressing how much it meant to them. And that's the moment where it kind of did hit me for a second.

(57:11 - 57:26)

That aspect of it was obviously, it was very nice. But to your point, it was an extra, also an extra responsibility, I felt, in a positive way. You obviously have a responsibility to do a good job in

general.

(57:27 - 58:10)

But, you know, I wanted to also make sure I did an extra good job, because I was the first, representing a lot of hopes and dreams of a community that I wanted to make sure that I could make them proud as well. It's also crazy because the British ruled India up until 1947. And, you know, in a world where we still speak about things like racism, is there a line, like, while you speak to me, and I watched a bunch of interviews, almost everything I think you guys have done in the recent past, but you're very Indian in a way where you took oath on the Gita, you have Diwali parties, you speak about her parents a lot.

(58:10 - 58:37)

Is there a line where you could become too Indian in a way that while you're actively in politics in England, it could become a problem? It never did. Well, whether it was going to or not, for me, it was non-negotiable. And I wasn't going to change who I was to make that work.

(58:37 - 58:49)

So even if someone had come to me and said, you need to be a bit less Indian or not talk about this or do that, I just wouldn't have. You know, we talked about it. I made that commitment to myself.

(58:50 - 58:57)

I wasn't going to change who I was for that. To get ahead in this. Yeah, and I was comfortable with it.

(58:57 - 59:23)

If it was going to be a problem, then so be it, right? You know, it just, it was never, that was how I was raised, right? That's who I am. I wasn't going to run away from it just because I had that job. And I also think, actually, it was a moment that was remarked on, obviously, in the UK when it happened.

(59:23 - 59:33)

But not so much so. It's not like it really dominated the conversations and that's all everyone was talking about. And people had plenty of issues with me as Prime Minister.

(59:33 - 59:47)

That was not really the reason that, you know, if someone was going to be upset with me, it wasn't going to be for that. But why not? Why didn't it become a bigger deal? Well, I think it's

probably because of the country, right? And how it's, you know. It could never happen in the US, for example.

(59:47 - 59:55)

Every country has a different, yeah. But it was a big deal when it happened. More so than it probably was with me.

(59:55 - 1:00:06)

And I think just all countries have their own relationship with these types of topics. And the UK has come a long way. And that's why I think it's a good thing that it wasn't a big deal.

(1:00:06 - 1:00:11)

It was a kind of, oh, okay. And then we move on. And they'll be upset with me about this or that.

(1:00:11 - 1:00:19)

But not because, you know, I didn't like what you said here or what you did there. And that's why. Not because you, you know, you let a Diwali Diya outside the door.

(1:00:19 - 1:00:27)

Correct. Or you went back to the temple last weekend or something. I know how it felt so meaningful to us.

(1:00:27 - 1:00:34)

It was so meaningful to our communities. But we didn't even second guess it. Because it felt so natural.

(1:00:35 - 1:00:43)

And no one made us feel like we should second guess it. If that makes sense, right? Like we didn't feel uncomfortable at all. And I think that's the beauty of the UK.

(1:00:44 - 1:01:03)

Is your ability to genuinely believe in what you do. It was a, it was a very nice moment. Because when you become Prime Minister, you have to go see the monarch, who was the king, who had recently become king.

(1:01:04 - 1:01:13)

And he informally invites you to form a government. That's how the process works. And so I go

along to see him before I go to Downing Street.

(1:01:14 - 1:01:28)

And that was a special moment. You know, he's head of the Church of England, as well as being the king and the monarch and head of state. But has always been someone who's talked about being a defender of faith.

(1:01:28 - 1:01:40)

Not just the faith in general. And here I was, first British Asian Hindu Prime Minister of the UK. But the nice thing was, you know, we had tea in the afternoon.

(1:01:40 - 1:01:56)

But because it was Diwali, and he's someone who's always been very engaged and supportive of the British Asian community in the UK. And there were Diwali Mithai. So it was not like tea and scones.

(1:01:56 - 1:02:11)

Tea and Mithai that he'd organised. Which was a really lovely, kind of relatively unremarked moment. And to me, I thought that was a... How are they? How are... The monarchs.

(1:02:11 - 1:02:24)

Well, we have this... I've met them a few times. I'm in that British Asian Trust. I also have a colleague of mine who used to be the ex-chief of staff for Prince Charles.

(1:02:24 - 1:02:27)

King Charles. King Charles, yeah. So I met him a few times.

(1:02:27 - 1:02:37)

But in the very shake hand, hi, how are you, that kind of way. But how are they? They're wonderfully warm people. Yes.

(1:02:38 - 1:02:47)

As Prime Minister, you see the king or previously queen every week for what's called an audience. I watched this in the Winston Churchill documentary, I think. Ah, okay.

(1:02:48 - 1:03:03)

The meetings, yeah. Yeah, so you have these meetings weekly. And then the other thing that is a

cast iron rule of UK government and politicians is that you don't ever talk about the royal family or your dialogue with them.

(1:03:03 - 1:03:20)

But other than to say, as Akshatha said, as you can see, very warm and very welcoming people who are committed to service. Service, yeah. But particularly, as I said, with King Charles, as you saw, the British Asian Trust, it's something that he's supported for years and years.

(1:03:20 - 1:03:34)

I'm not going to ask you anything controversial. But the thing that did impress me about Prince Charles is... King Charles. King Charles is, he was into the climate thing 20, 30 years before other people were into it.

(1:03:34 - 1:03:39)

Yeah. Which I thought was very forward looking. Yeah.

(1:03:40 - 1:03:48)

He's a huge, I think, like he really is a naturalist in so many ways, I think. Yeah. He's very passionate about that.

(1:03:49 - 1:03:53)

He's very passionate about the natural environment. Yeah. He's very knowledgeable about it as well.

(1:03:54 - 1:04:00)

Okay. Tell me more about how it felt. After, okay, the first day, you felt like you didn't have time to react.

(1:04:00 - 1:04:18)

Yeah. Because you were in whatever tumultuous, busy, busy, crazy madness warrior zone. But what happens three months later, six months later? At some point, you take cognizance of it, right? Like you wake up every day and suddenly you have like all the security and this and that.

(1:04:19 - 1:04:26)

I've been to 10 Downing Street. Your house changes significantly overnight. Who did you visit? Meaning which prime minister? I think it was Boris.

(1:04:26 - 1:04:30)

It was Boris at the time. But it has beautiful art in that. I was so impressed.

(1:04:30 - 1:04:36)

Someone took me for a tour. Yeah. So we were fortunate in one sense because we'd already been living in Downing Street.

(1:04:37 - 1:04:52)

Not everyone knows, but there are two apartments, flats in Downing Street, one for the prime minister and one for the chancellor. So, you know, for us and for our kids, we were used to that. It was a familiar space.

(1:04:52 - 1:05:14)

So the very physical and practical aspect of having security or living in this building with everything that came along with that was something that we were used to and our kids were used to. And we made the decision not to change flats when I went from becoming chancellor to becoming prime minister. Historically, you would move.

(1:05:15 - 1:05:23)

And we made a decision not to do that. We stayed in the smaller... So we were staying in the same apartment, right? So we stayed in the same place. Precisely for our kids, so they had that.

(1:05:23 - 1:05:34)

And for us, we had the familiarity with it. And actually, it's a funny but lovely environment for the kids. Our younger daughter loves history.

(1:05:34 - 1:05:44)

So she would love being in this building with, to your point, all the history and art. And she'd give the best tour. By the time we left, give the best tour of Downing Street.

(1:05:44 - 1:06:00)

And then there are all the incredible staff that live and work there. For decades even, a lot of them. And they spoil the kids, right? So the kids would go to their security room and get sweets and have fun looking at all the security cameras and kind of spotting what was going on.

(1:06:00 - 1:06:06)

So it was like home away from home. So they felt very welcome. Obviously, it's a bit odd.

(1:06:09 - 1:06:18)

But it's a bit strange when the Deliveroo or Uber Eats person shows up at the back... Zomato. Yeah, exactly. It shows up at the back gate.

(1:06:18 - 1:06:25)

Is Zomato in London? I don't think so. I don't think so, no. But the kids love it.

(1:06:25 - 1:06:41)

Actually, the lovely lady who ran the cafeteria in Downing Street would always spoil our kids with kind of bacon sandwiches in the mornings on their way to school and things like that. So there are these all... And we got our dog, Nova, while we were in Downing Street. So she came there as a puppy.

(1:06:41 - 1:06:51)

So she also got spoiled by hundreds of people. So that very kind of nice aspect, you kind of are growing up in this community. And living in.

(1:06:52 - 1:06:59)

Living in. Now, that has its downsides, obviously. Our flat door in Downing Street is much smaller than people realise.

(1:07:00 - 1:07:12)

It's very kind of higgledy-piggledy in our offices and flats. So you'd open our front door to our flat and the Downing Street policy unit breakout area is literally... You open the door and there's people sitting there having a meeting. Quite a few tantrums.

(1:07:13 - 1:07:26)

Yeah, like the kids are screaming on your way, like, good morning. And, you know, while they're trying to figure something out. So, you know, those are some kind of day-to-day aspects of it that you get used to.

(1:07:26 - 1:07:48)

But for us, as I said, the transition was, we hadn't got used to a lot of that in any case. Who was the smartest person you think you met while you were in office? Who was the smartest? Both of you. And what did you take away? I find this very, very attractive that you get to meet... So many interesting, different types of people.

(1:07:48 - 1:08:00)

Yeah, I would just say, like, really, really smart people. Or really, really accomplished people which is not necessarily the same as being smart, but really successful people. We have to think about that.

(1:08:00 - 1:08:41)

But can I just talk about the smart? You say smart, but I'll give you probably an unorthodox answer, Nikhil. So I, you know, we've talked a lot about the power of education to transform people's lives. And so when Rishi became PM, I thought about, well, what can I do in my own small way to add some value? Because unlike the US, the UK doesn't have a formal role for the spouse, right? And so... But I also knew that I would... Or I wanted to, in some small way, have some impact in my own way.

(1:08:41 - 1:08:51)

And so I started this program called Lessons at Ten. So every Friday, we got kids in from across the country to come in and be inspired. I mean, the theme was be inspired.

(1:08:51 - 1:09:09)

Be inspired by the building, be inspired by leadership, be inspired to dream. And then every week we had a different theme. So you might love history, I might love rugby, Rishi might love finance, whatever, cooking, I mean, across the range.

(1:09:09 - 1:09:34)

So don't feel like there's only one thing for you. Just go out and explore, and you might just find that thing that gets you out of bed. And every week, Nikhil, I met young people who didn't always... In fact, a lot of the time, didn't come with huge kind of advantages in life, but they were so inspiring to me.

(1:09:34 - 1:09:47)

And I think... Thank you. I think that is a memory that will stay with me forever. So it wasn't just one famous person, right? It wasn't one famous name, but it was young people.

(1:09:48 - 1:10:09)

You know, with their idealism, I think that was really quite interesting and exciting. I don't know what you think. Yeah, I don't... I think there's not one... Can I serve you? Oh, yes.

I will help myself. Yeah, I don't want to... Are you having... Yeah, I'll help myself. Thank you.

(1:10:10 - 1:10:18)

There you go. I'll let you... I don't think there's... I think there's some special moments. I mean, there are lots of special moments.

(1:10:20 - 1:10:29)

I'm thinking like the coronation was really special. In terms of individuals, but you're... Nicole's asking about the smarts. I mean, look, there's... People are smart in so many different ways.

(1:10:29 - 1:10:47)

You're not one person. There's all... All dominant knowledge, but... I mean, look, we're living in this era of AI. And... You know, I was struck spending time with the people developing that technology.

(1:10:47 - 1:11:05)

And you know them, you've interviewed them, you've met them, but... Sam, Dario, and Demis, who's obviously a Brit, came to talk to me about this very early on in my premiership. And... You interviewed Elon. I interviewed Elon as well.

(1:11:05 - 1:11:07)

I watched that. It was really good. AI summit.

(1:11:07 - 1:11:16)

You looked like you were really having fun. Yeah, I was... I mean, I was... Yes, I was. Thank you.

(1:11:17 - 1:11:26)

That was the first AI safety summit. Yeah, that was on the AI... The evening of the AI summit. You know, so we had... It was a... Yeah, it was nice.

(1:11:26 - 1:11:46)

Obviously, being in India this... Recently for this AI summit here, when we started that summit in Bletchley Park, I didn't imagine that it would end up... Not end up, but progress to have this incredible event here in India. And it's nice to have created this series. And it's been to South Korea, it's been to Paris, India, and it will keep going.

(1:11:47 - 1:12:06)

How was it, this year, the summit? It was great. It was... I think it's kind of a testament to the prime minister's leadership that he brought so many of the leading businesses and... And human companies. Policymakers together.

(1:12:06 - 1:12:28)

But I think it was... For me, what stood out was just the energy and optimism of all Indian entrepreneurs and people involved in this. It was really striking. Just being in the hall, talking to people, such optimism about this, which is not what you find everywhere.

(1:12:28 - 1:12:38)

And particularly in the West, where there is more anxiety about AI. In India, there's optimism and excitement and trust. And that is an advantage.

(1:12:39 - 1:12:53)

Then you also saw the... He's incredibly impressive, isn't he, the prime minister? Yes, he's very impressive. Look, I used to talk to him about this when I was in office. He's been talking about the India stack for a long time.

(1:12:53 - 1:13:01)

Do you guys speak in Hindi or English? English. My Hindi is not good enough to do work. I would not trust it to do any serious work.

(1:13:01 - 1:13:16)

Any serious work with, sadly. But he's someone who's understood the importance of technology, the importance of the tech stack. And as you see the announcement from Sarvam, which was superb.

(1:13:16 - 1:13:33)

I mean, DPI, Aadhaar and UPI, and now there's Ayushman Bharat Health Accounts. You put all that together, the ability to deploy AI applications to over a billion people is, again, distinctive advantage for India. So, you know, all the ingredients are there.

(1:13:33 - 1:14:09)

Do you believe sovereign AI has a use case? Sovereign AI? Like what Sarvam was trying to build? Yeah, so my approach to sovereignty and AI is... And I've been thinking about this a lot. I think... And sovereignty and technology in general is... My advice to political leaders or what I would do if I was in office is I think you need to do three things. The first is you need as a country to figure out where you can ideally control a part of a critical technology supply chain.

(1:14:10 - 1:14:32)

So I think it's not realistic for most countries to think they can completely insource an end-to-end

supply chain, certainly for a country like the UK, for example. What do you suspect is that opportunity for India? Well, people here will know better than me, but it's trying to identify... You mean hardware supply chain? But it could be a hardware capability. It could be a software capability.

(1:14:32 - 1:14:51)

It could be physical. It could be something... It could be quite broadly defined, but something that... As I said, very unlikely that you can end-to-end insource a supply chain. But think about ASML, that company, critical component of the semi-supply chain.

(1:14:51 - 1:15:04)

So if you're the Netherlands, that's good for you to have. In a world where hard power matters, the world is more fragmented. The geopolitical environment is more competitive.

(1:15:05 - 1:15:21)

I think to protect yourself, you need to have an ASML strategy. So figure out, in the technologies of the future, where can you develop a capability that the world will need? So that's point one. The second point, and where Sarvam comes into it, is you have to diversify your risk and take a portfolio approach.

(1:15:21 - 1:15:40)

So there will be some... And what does that mean? It means not having vendor lock-in, right? Making sure you're building applications and systems that are not reliant on a single provider. And look, for some things, you want a frontier US model. Some things, you want to have data sovereignty and being provided domestically.

(1:15:41 - 1:16:02)

You don't need that for everything. But what you need to do is think about your portfolio, figure out where you can dial some things up and dial some things down, where can you use open source, where can you rely on Sarvam, where is it fine to pull something off the shelf from another country that you can switch in and out? So that's where Sarvam comes in, is building that portfolio approach. And then the third thing is partnerships.

(1:16:03 - 1:16:40)

And actually, yes, the world is more contested, but partnerships matter, trust matters, and there will be some things that you can work with other countries on to mean that... You don't have to... You can't do everything yourself, but you have enough trusted relationships that you can rely on them. And again, you wouldn't fully rely on them, but as I said, these three components, if you do

all three of those, you're giving yourself as much sovereignty as possible. But what does that mean, sovereignty? What it means is an ability to deploy the technology confidently in your own country according to your values, your laws, your priorities.

(1:16:40 - 1:16:52)

But you say deploy and not develop. Oh, sorry. In order to deploy it in accordance with your... And have reliable, trusted access to being able to deploy it, which is why you need that portfolio approach.

(1:16:53 - 1:17:25)

And actually having some... Whether you're relying on open source or homegrown models all plays into a part of that. But in a way, you're saying it's better for a country to rely on homegrown or open source rather than relying on American or Chinese? I don't think you can be that binary, Nikhil. I think if you look at the range of use cases and what's realistic for any one country to do, you have to look at your approach to technology as a portfolio, and then there will be a range.

(1:17:25 - 1:17:38)

If I've got very sensitive national security applications, I want probably an air-gapped cloud. I don't want to be reliant on anyone else. I can't have anyone else kill switch that.

(1:17:38 - 1:17:53)

If I'm doing a healthcare application domestically, I might be a bit more okay with the model provider as long as I don't have lock-in and I can switch out different providers. Could be open source, could be domestic, could be foreign. And you would be skeptical of sharing data.

(1:17:53 - 1:18:16)

But I would want the data to stay, right? There, I would want my data sovereignty and I'd want the compute to be domestic. And then there'll be some other commercial applications where actually it's quicker and easier and cheaper to use some foreign thing and it's not mission critical and it's just actually I want to prioritize cost and speed. I think India has done it for financial data already.

(1:18:16 - 1:18:30)

It's hosted in India. I suspect soon all Indian data will be hosted in India. Look, all countries, not just India, all countries are thinking about these issues differently to how they did in the past because the geopolitical environment has changed.

(1:18:30 - 1:18:45)

So you have to think about sovereignty. We're in a world where countries have weaponized

supply chains. There's more geopolitical competition and you can't afford not to have resilience.

(1:18:45 - 1:19:04)

And you think the world will continue to move in this direction where we're kind of like, I don't know if I can call it de-globalization. It's de-risking, it's de-risking. I think, you know, if you think about supply chain, it used to be all about just in time, physical supply chain used to be all about just in time and now it's about just in case.

(1:19:04 - 1:19:30)

But do you mean how countries now operate on their own versus the kind of coming together global order? There used to be like, I think consensus building, maybe up until five years ago. Right now it seems to be everybody for themselves. I think it's not as stark as that in the sense that you have to be more resilient.

(1:19:30 - 1:19:43)

You have to think about sovereignty because that multilateral rules-based system, much as it existed. Let me give you an analogy you will like. Like cricket used to have a World Cup where all the countries in the world came to play and compete.

(1:19:43 - 1:20:07)

Now there are 20 different leagues, one big league, many small leagues, some irrelevant leagues, something like that. Maybe triggered by the Americans with tariffs and everything else that they're doing. I do still think there is a role for partnerships and cooperation.

(1:20:07 - 1:20:24)

So look what India's just done, signed trade agreement with the UK, signed a trade agreement with the EU. The EU has signed a trade agreement with Latin America. The UK joined the Trans-Pacific Partnership, is currently talking to the Gulf about doing that.

(1:20:24 - 1:20:36)

So the ASEAN countries are figuring out how to deepen their economic cooperation. So yes, the US has changed its approach. And not just with this administration, those changes have been in place for a while.

(1:20:36 - 1:20:54)

It's changed its approach to trade in particular and how it views global defence. But that doesn't mean that other countries have given up on the idea that there can be mutually beneficial trading relationships. So lots of different partnerships.

(1:20:54 - 1:21:16)

And that they can form mutually beneficial partnerships, whether that's in technology, whether that's in goods, whether that's in sharing critical minerals, supply chains. So I don't think it's as stark as every country is just out for itself. But clearly, you have to, if you're running a country, be more focused on resilience and sovereignty than you were five years ago.

(1:21:16 - 1:21:31)

Are governments forgiving? Does it come down to one person? I'm just painting a scenario. Let's assume Trump's era comes to an end and there is a new president. I don't know, it could be his vice president, it could be Democrats, whoever comes into power.

(1:21:32 - 1:21:50)

And the UK has a new prime minister. Do you go back to zero and start all over? Or do you remember and you think that, oh, this person did this? So a couple of things. One is to remember that some of these forces have been in place before President Trump.

(1:21:52 - 1:22:06)

And do I think a future US president is going to suddenly cut all the tariffs? No. The baseline of tariffs to the US is going to be higher in the future. I think regardless of who the president is.

(1:22:07 - 1:22:19)

Not least because whoever the new president is will have got used to the tariff revenue. It's quite a hard thing to get rid of. Do you believe that tariffs are inherently a bad thing? Because many countries have custom duties.

(1:22:20 - 1:22:28)

Yes, they do. Look, I'm someone who generally believes in free trade. I'm on the free trade side of things.

(1:22:29 - 1:23:02)

I think it's important that that trade is fair and there are level playing fields, which is why if I think about China's experience in joining the global trade system, when that decision was made in 2001, then there was, I think at the time, reasonable belief that bringing China into that system would, A, impact its political outlook. Like take China, for example. But what happened is China didn't play by the same set of trading rules that everyone else played with.

(1:23:02 - 1:23:18)

So how do you deal with something like that? If I were China and I say, I will not let your technology enter my country. I will build replicas and subsidize it for my own people. I will put tariffs on all the goods that are American coming into my country.

(1:23:19 - 1:23:54)

What is left in America's playbook? I'll also artificially deflate my currency to make my trade more competent than yours. What's left in America's playbook than to mimic the action of the other country? And that's where I think, as I said, the trade has to be fair and on a level playing field. And if you haven't got that, then this kind of free trade model that works in theory, it's harder to explain to your citizens and to say that this is fine in practice.

(1:23:54 - 1:24:13)

And it's not just the US. The EU has done the same thing with putting tariffs on Chinese electric vehicles because of the subsidization that happens domestically, which is then, that's not a level playing field. If people are freely, fairly competing, then trade can be mutually beneficial.

(1:24:13 - 1:24:32)

But if one side is unfairly advantaging its exporters with government subsidies to that extent, and then they have artificially low prices, then obviously countries are going to take action. And again, that's not just the US, that's the EU. So I... Can I make a counter argument to that? Yeah.

(1:24:32 - 1:25:01)

I don't remember what book I was reading this in, but at one point in time in UK's history, Birmingham was the center of innovation. A lot of the patents that were being created in the world happened in that one tiny place. I don't remember where I read this, but they were making a case for how Birmingham and the local economy shut down to foreign products so the industry locally could thrive.

(1:25:02 - 1:25:29)

And when they came up to scale and came up to a certain quality, they opened up all over again. Yeah, there's an infant industry argument that has... As I said, every stage, every country will have a different approach to this. But in general, between developed countries, where there is a similarity in approach, freer trade is better, in my view.

(1:25:30 - 1:25:59)

The key is, is it being done in a fair way, where there's a level playing field? And particularly with China, that has not been the case, which is a problem. And I think it will increasingly become a problem because more and more countries are having to deal with the Chinese development

model, which is very export-oriented, where, to your point, they don't prioritize domestic consumption, they prioritize exports. And then lots of countries now are absorbing a huge amount of Chinese imports.

(1:26:00 - 1:26:07)

Including India. The rest of the world. If you look at what's happened, the US obviously has slowed that down.

(1:26:07 - 1:26:18)

Chinese exports, though, and the Chinese trade surplus is at a record high as a percentage of global GDP. So all those exports are going to all these other countries. So I think there'll be increasing tension with these other countries.

(1:26:18 - 1:26:44)

The EU has already put on tariffs on Chinese EVs. So I think you will see that. But look, this focus on your point, though, about your question about what happens if there's a new president, where do things reset to? COVID also was the clarifying moment that many of us lived through in government that made us all focus about supply chains and the resilience of those supply chains.

(1:26:44 - 1:26:56)

So you don't forget that. And that changes your approach. I think those people who worry about national security were nervous around Huawei telecoms equipment.

(1:26:56 - 1:27:11)

That was the other big event that happened while I was in government, where we went through a process of deciding that we weren't going to rely on Chinese telecoms equipment. And before AI, we were focused on that. And that was an expensive and disruptive decision for many countries to take.

(1:27:11 - 1:27:27)

These things stay. Regardless of who the US president is, or British prime minister, those are structural features that now need to be incorporated into your thinking. I'm not going to talk to Akshita like she's Rishi's wife or Narayan Modi's daughter.

(1:27:30 - 1:27:44)

I think you've been dealt, if this were a poker game, a really hard set of cards. I don't play poker, so I will follow along. I can translate you.

(1:27:45 - 1:28:05)

But sure, I get it. But you were saying dealt a hard set of cards. Yeah, I feel like there is an emotional tax to being interpreted as an extremely successful man's daughter.

(1:28:06 - 1:28:25)

Where if we were to define happiness as rate of change in a way, very hard to get there. I think people often look at the children of very accomplished men. Versus women, you mean? Men and women.

(1:28:25 - 1:28:32)

Yeah. As being lucky. But I think the counter is true.

(1:28:32 - 1:28:52)

I feel like they're some of the most unluckiest people because it's so much harder for them to actually feel a sense of accomplishment. Sense of self, right? And then to have your husband suddenly become the prime minister, it can't have been fun for you. So interesting.

(1:28:52 - 1:29:11)

So a couple of things. I'm hugely proud of my dad and I'm hugely proud of Rishi. But do you know, Nikhil, and this comes back to that unorthodox thinking that I have, I haven't let it burden me as much.

(1:29:12 - 1:29:33)

So let's talk about my dad. It's partly a timing thing. Infosys was not this kind of, what it became in time, hugely successful tech start, what was a startup and then became a tech business.

(1:29:34 - 1:30:06)

It was a company my dad started because he was looking at how could he add value to India? And he thought originally, you know, all of this, right? He thought communism was the way and then he had this stint in Western Europe and became a big fan of capitalism. So he was thinking, well, how can I? He told me some crazy stories around that. What happened when he was hitchhiking, all of that, right? That's like a whole another podcast.

(1:30:06 - 1:30:43)

But so for him, he figured out that economic development and economic success gave you a great deal of power on the global stage. And so he said, well, how can I play a small role in helping India develop that credibility and stand taller? Having said that, it was not an overnight

success. And so I saw him in many ways beavering away, right? At something he believed in.

(1:30:44 - 1:31:18)

He had a emphasis. I don't know if you remember, but the motto that he came up with was powered by intellect, driven by values. Right.

So he was someone who had a strong, has still a strong moral compass. And he believed that you power that moral compass with deep intellectual rigor and with skills that he had, which happened to be in the tech space while he was an engineer. But it was not an overnight success.

(1:31:18 - 1:31:47)

I'm not saying it was a failure, but it took a long time. So I grew up very much being my own person, partly my thinking, partly circumstances. And by the time emphasis became more well known, I was studying in the U.S. And that also was a slightly unorthodox choice because I guess I could have gone into engineering in India.

(1:31:48 - 1:31:57)

But that wasn't my passion. And I always valued breadth and the liberal arts education offered that. And that was on the West Coast in California.

(1:31:58 - 1:32:09)

So it was far away somewhat. And always made my professional decisions. You know, I got the jobs I did on my own.

(1:32:10 - 1:32:21)

I pursued opportunities that I created. And so while I was hugely proud of my father, I was also used to standing on my own two feet. Right.

(1:32:22 - 1:32:51)

And then I met Rishi. And this has nothing to do with my parents' success, but he reminded me a lot of my dad because he too, like my father, had this huge passion for his country. And I remember one of the things, Rishi, you said very early on, we were talking about how your parents' journey to the U.K. had transformed your family's life.

(1:32:52 - 1:33:12)

And then, you know, they, of course, worked really hard to provide you with this education. And you would one day hope to grow up and in your own way, create a platform, create opportunities for lots of other young Rishis to have, boys and girls to have these kinds of opportunities. So that

reminded me a lot of my dad.

(1:33:14 - 1:33:33)

And so I was, again, you know, Rishi wasn't in the plan for many reasons, but I, but it was inspiring to me. And so for me, my dad has always been someone, yes, he's been successful. He's done really well, et cetera.

(1:33:33 - 1:33:46)

But to me, he's been an inspiring figure. And that's what I've taken away from it and said, how can I then introduce that in my own life, through my own journey? And by the way, I'm not a technologist. I'm not an engineer.

(1:33:48 - 1:34:00)

And I never felt bad about that because it was very clear to me from very early on, I'm going to carve my own path. And so, absolutely. And my, and look, you know, Rishi and I got together, et cetera.

(1:34:00 - 1:34:09)

Rishi became PM. But even then, that's what I was talking about lessons at 10, right? Rishi's PM, he does his thing. I would never interfere in his role, in his job.

(1:34:09 - 1:34:32)

But I was very clear that I was also going to, in some way, thank you, for, create my own path and do something that I deeply cared about. And so, I guess I'm, I didn't feel the pressure in the same way. Right.

(1:34:34 - 1:34:52)

And so I don't, for lack of a better term, I don't have a chip on my shoulder about it. I think I feel, thank you. I feel quite grateful that I've had through, for many different reasons, access to so many opportunities.

(1:34:53 - 1:35:10)

And every time I'm thinking, how can I make it my own? And that's been something from when I was very young. So forget Rishi and your dad. Where does Akshita's validation come from? So one of my values, I have three values.

(1:35:10 - 1:35:24)

And we've spoken about some of those things. Compassion, curiosity, and personal integrity. And

personal integrity to me is, I define it as being authentic to who I am.

(1:35:25 - 1:35:40)

Others may not like it. Others may not understand it. But if it sits well inside of me, you know, we're talking earlier about intuition, right? I lean into my intuition more than average.

(1:35:40 - 1:35:52)

Certainly between the two of us, I'm more on the intuitive side. I think my, look, I'm not going to say I'm holier than thou and I don't see validation. Of course not.

(1:35:52 - 1:36:10)

All of us do. I really care about having impact. Right? So what does that mean? You know, when we apply to Stanford, they ask you to write this essay.

(1:36:10 - 1:36:30)

And even today, they still ask you to write the same essay. It's called, at least one of the few essays you have to write. The question is, what matters most to you and why? And I remember writing about rain in Mumbai, actually.

(1:36:32 - 1:36:54)

Because around that time, I was 23, we were, I haven't sort of spent a long time in Mumbai in a little while. But you know, the monsoon can be quite heavy. And for those of us who have a roof over our heads, we can observe the monsoon and say, oh, that's pleasant.

(1:36:56 - 1:37:14)

But for those of us who don't, it's less pleasant. And so I wrote about equality and how do I help create a society where there is more equality. Equality of wealth? Equality of opportunity, at least.

(1:37:15 - 1:37:19)

Not outcome. Not outcome. And look, I was 23, hugely idealistic.

(1:37:20 - 1:37:41)

And I really wanted to do something that helped society in some way, the broader society. And I'd seen my parents through, my dad through Infosys and then my mother through the Infosys Foundation, marry that impact from capitalism to philanthropy. And I was, that really moved me.

(1:37:42 - 1:38:04)

And it's what we used to talk about And it's what we used to discuss a lot about, even at Stanford. And we'd have these big, not big, but we'd have these debates, right? About CSR and, I come at it from a bit more of a, traditionally, capitalistic, economic way. Economic argument, yeah.

(1:38:05 - 1:38:29)

And actually stood out for, especially in a business school environment, you always stood out because you were always like the one person in whatever study group or class. Well, how does it impact society? How does it impact the most vulnerable people? How does it? I think it's all validation. If one person gets validation through a capitalistic win, another gets it through a moralistic win or an altruistic win.

(1:38:30 - 1:38:34)

It's all validation. No, fair enough. I feel like we're all seeking the same height.

(1:38:34 - 1:38:38)

The pathway is different. Different, yeah. Yeah, no, fair enough.

(1:38:38 - 1:38:45)

That's fair. This pathway comes further down the journey than that pathway. Because I think you have to win at capitalism before you can win at morality.

(1:38:45 - 1:38:55)

True, true. And that was... And many people will say, Nikhil, all well and good that you want to be altruistic, you don't have to pay the bills. You don't have to worry about paying the bills, right? I get that.

(1:38:55 - 1:39:03)

But then I also feel a huge sense of responsibility as a result. And to your point, you need to do the first bit. To do the second.

(1:39:03 - 1:39:29)

Which is what your dad did, right? You have that impact only because you've been able to create wealth and create the platform. So either I can bemoan that and say, oh no, I'm either person X's daughter or person Y's wife, etc. Or I can say I'm hugely lucky to have what I have.

(1:39:29 - 1:39:42)

What do I do with it? So in a sense, that blank canvas, I've had much earlier in my life. Yeah. And

let me tell you, some of the pictures I've drawn, I've not been pretty, right? But I've had the blank canvas.

(1:39:42 - 1:39:57)

And I think that's... It's also a little bit my personality. I don't... It's that poem that you gave me when we first met. One of the first gifts you gave me.

(1:39:57 - 1:40:01)

Are you that guy who gives poems? No, he is not. I think I did. One.

(1:40:02 - 1:40:07)

One. Before he said, oh yeah, I am that guy. I was going to be like, no.

(1:40:08 - 1:40:14)

It was early on. It's only just been one. It has only just been one.

(1:40:15 - 1:40:22)

But anyway, but I knew of it anyway. That's why you gave it to me, not like you introduced me to it. By Rudyard Kipling called If.

(1:40:22 - 1:41:02)

And my mother reminds me all the time that these words are painted or carved in the changing rooms in Centre Court in Wimbledon before you go out to play the tennis match. I'm not going to quote it exactly at all, but if you look at winning and losing as two sides of the same coin, then you're truly a man, right? If you treat triumph and disaster as two impostors just the same, right? I think that's the kind of stuff with me. That is how you are built that way.

(1:41:02 - 1:41:10)

That is my approach to life, Nikhil. So I started a fashion business. We finished business school and then I was working in brand consulting.

(1:41:12 - 1:41:24)

During business school, I'd written a... Before you get... But that point on the... That is very who you are. You are much more... Which I've learned from. Good things happen.

(1:41:25 - 1:41:31)

Don't get carried away. Not that you're not... Grateful, appreciative, all of that. Like when Rishi

became PM.

(1:41:32 - 1:42:01)

It's a huge moment, but it didn't... That's why I think we both kind of struggled to answer that question, because it wasn't like... Not because we don't honour it and are hugely proud of that moment. Great triumph. But equally, anyone who's had great triumph will tell you, you also see great disasters, right? I think it's very evolved that you accept the cards that you're dealt.

(1:42:02 - 1:42:33)

Because many others in your position really struggle with it. I'll tell you another thing that is bad today. I don't know if it's good or bad, but... For somebody who gets their high from the moralistic, altruistic wins in life, society or pop culture has suddenly become conditioned in a manner where anybody who goes out and says they're doing something to do good, the general emotion is distrust.

(1:42:33 - 1:42:39)

Yeah. So you're not trying... Swimming against the tide. Yeah.

(1:42:40 - 1:43:07)

The timing is difficult. But there again, Nikhil, that's who I am, right? And that doesn't mean I have won as such at life, right? I've had my ups, I've had my downs. But I know I will always have stayed true to who I am and what my beliefs are.

(1:43:08 - 1:43:17)

And you have a very clear sense of that. Yeah, I have a clear sense of who I am. Yeah, you have much... I'm not going to impose that on you.

(1:43:18 - 1:43:27)

I mean, I impose that a bit on you. But we... In a nice way. But it's so liberating.

(1:43:28 - 1:43:42)

And another way to look at it is during the pandemic, Rishi became chancellor, which all happened quite suddenly. So I was with the kids a lot. And, you know, you're just trying to figure out how to live this new life.

(1:43:42 - 1:43:55)

And I picked up Herman Hesse's book called Siddhartha, I guess. And you read about what Lord Buddha said. And it's the middle path.

(1:43:56 - 1:44:03)

It's the balance. That doesn't mean you shun... Desire. Desire.

(1:44:04 - 1:44:18)

But equally, you don't shun austerity. Right? You embrace both, in a way. Because what comes out of that, those two extremes, comes the middle path.

(1:44:20 - 1:44:23)

Anushka was saying this the other day. She's our youngest daughter. She's 13.

(1:44:24 - 1:44:38)

She said, the Romans, I hope, because I don't know this philosophy as well as she does. She was talking about the Stoics versus the Epicureans. The Epicureans are all about... More Greek than Romans.

(1:44:38 - 1:44:52)

More Greek, actually, exactly. The Epicureans embraced desire and amusement. And the Stoics somewhat shun that.

(1:44:53 - 1:45:15)

But actually, the happy place is somewhere in the middle. And it's not... You're not on the moral high ground if you think you are a Stoic versus an Epicurean. And that's the balance, right? So I have always chased, for lack of a better word, that balance.

(1:45:16 - 1:45:46)

And so even in the highs of highs of my parents' success, and they've had their highs and their lows, like any human being, even in the highs and lows of our own life together, I've tried. I don't always succeed at finding that balance. Do you think you need to retain that balance throughout? Or is it okay to allow yourself to drift between both the sides? I definitely drift between both.

(1:45:46 - 1:46:11)

And in fact, I remember one of the first things my mother said to me, Oh, what do you like about Rishi? And I said, He just allows me to have more fun. And we were talking earlier how our parents are different. My family is more reserved, intellectual, quieter.

(1:46:12 - 1:46:23)

I'm not saying that's bad and one is good. But I met Rishi, who was lots of energy and lots of excitement about so many different things. And so I thought that was amazing.

(1:46:23 - 1:46:37)

A different way of looking at life. The balance comes from embracing both, I think. Because then you say, Oh, this doesn't quite feel right all the time or this doesn't quite feel right.

(1:46:38 - 1:46:53)

And then you might say, Well, how do you know? I think there's a feeling inside. Whether you want to call that intuition, it's gut, it's a kind of deep feeling you get. And I've had that as a young person.

(1:46:53 - 1:47:04)

I have a theory for this. I feel like us South Indians never saw war as frequently as the North Indians did. We didn't see conflict.

(1:47:04 - 1:47:10)

I have the exact same theory. People who don't know how long they're going to live for. Embrace the moment.

(1:47:11 - 1:47:15)

Embrace the moment. I think we have to learn from them to embrace the moment a bit more. Completely.

(1:47:17 - 1:47:40)

In fact, I would say, I remember even in our wedding, my mother and I, we have these kinds of discussions and we both love history. And that's exactly what her and I said is, in general, North Indian weddings tend to be bolder and quite fun. And South Indian weddings seem more tame in comparison.

(1:47:41 - 1:47:58)

And you're absolutely right that you have to make the most of what you have when you have it. So again, no moral kind of judgment about it. But have that, but know that that life is not just about that.

(1:47:59 - 1:48:03)

Yeah. So maybe middle ground is the the middle path. Yeah.

(1:48:03 - 1:48:24)

Almost always the answer. For so many things. Yep.

Absolutely. Yeah. You have to, you have to develop that ability not to get carried away by success, but equally not to be so deflated by failure.

(1:48:25 - 1:49:12)

You know, that said, when thinking about the failure, there's good and bad ways to deal with it. You've got to turn it into something positive, but that requires a mindset where if something bad happens, your story, the story you tell yourself about it can't be one which is victim-centered, where this bad thing happened because I was a victim of this or victim of that and all these bad things happened to me. You have to be able to more objectively look at it and just self-reflect and say, what did I not quite get right? What did I misjudge? And then you can turn it into something positive where you say, okay, now how do I improve my process for the future? And you've always said this to me, you said you'd be kinder to yourself because I'd be beating myself up.

(1:49:12 - 1:49:35)

And you always say be kinder to yourself. I always say to Rishi, I say this to the girls because we have two teenage girls, they're 13 and 14, and I say, the person you have to be kindest to first is yourself because then you understand deep inside what that actually means before you can practice it in the real world. And I know we talk about that a lot.

(1:49:35 - 1:49:54)

And remember, if you're in these jobs, if you're leading, most of the decisions that you make, almost by definition, are 50-50 decisions. And if they were not, someone else would have made it. And so the only decisions that come to you are the exceptionally hard 50-50 ones.

(1:49:55 - 1:50:17)

And in terms of being kind to yourself, you have to recognize you're not going to get all of them right. And you are in that position. Someone else said this to me, a very successful technology executive said this to me at an early meeting he had with me, actually in Downing Street, and he said that you're in this position because your ability to make those decisions is on average better than most other people.

(1:50:17 - 1:50:21)

Your judgment is on average better. You wouldn't be sitting here. I wouldn't be talking to you.

(1:50:21 - 1:50:42)

So trust that and have some confidence in it. And then when things don't go right, as long as you're honestly self-reflective about it, recognize good and bad outcomes of the same process, reflect, and then think what you can learn from it, take away for the next time. That is a very... I mean, I learned how to do that, not perfectly, but because... Of course, still learning.

(1:50:42 - 1:50:48)

And you're still learning. But it's a very necessary part of being a good leader. No matter what you do, by the way.

(1:50:48 - 1:50:58)

No matter what you do. It's not just political leadership. Understanding these failures, how to cope with them, how to then turn them into something positive so that you grow and it doesn't consume you.

(1:50:58 - 1:51:14)

Because you can get into a negative spiral where it's very damaging. I've become really fascinated by this term called metacognition, right? Which is thinking about the thinking. So look at an outcome and you say, okay, outcome X happened.

(1:51:14 - 1:51:40)

Why did it happen? Why did I behave the way I did? Did I deploy my strengths and weaknesses? Why are those my strengths versus these? And then regulating your thinking. Meta-regulation, right? I thought, I think that is... Metacognitive regulation. I just think that's just a fascinating way for where humans are heading.

(1:51:41 - 1:51:47)

I find most words which have meta in the beginning are very interesting. Yes, there you go. Exactly.

(1:51:47 - 1:51:53)

Let's just add metacognition. It sounds good, yeah. Metacognitive regulation.

(1:51:53 - 1:52:02)

I must say, you both make a really good case for marriage. That's good to hear. On some days when it doesn't feel that way.

(1:52:03 - 1:52:10)

We're going to clip that and play it as a ringtone. Yeah, exactly. It's so weird you said that because that's exactly what it is.

(1:52:10 - 1:52:36)

I was going to say that's going to be our ringtone. We're very yin and yang. But it comes with more friction in a way because... But what we're talking about right at the beginning because we approach things differently and we are quite different, but there's a... I'm going to give... You know, there's a common set of values and so the product of it I think is better as a result of the combination of us on most things.

(1:52:36 - 1:52:41)

I'll give you a... We get to a better answer. I'll give you a silly example. I feel like I have to say this before your deep thought.

(1:52:41 - 1:52:50)

Okay, I've finished the deep thought. So Rishi turns... We turn 30 around the same time. We were in LA at the time and this new ice cream shop opened.

(1:52:50 - 1:52:59)

And I said to Rishi, you know, they have like 30 flavors. It's all natural, etc. And he's like, oh no, I just like vanilla.

(1:53:00 - 1:53:07)

So we go there and they do have 30 flavors, right? Like Schezwan, peppercorn ice cream. Wow, I love that. Yeah, passion fruit.

(1:53:07 - 1:53:15)

I don't know. Black pepper, all sorts of things. And I mean, Rishi picks vanilla.

(1:53:15 - 1:53:41)

And I'm like, what do you mean? And he's like, well, what would you pick? And on purpose, I picked the most bizarre flavor that is because that's kind of my approach to life. Like give me a situation and I will look at it with a totally risk-taking mindset. Whereas Rishi, that wouldn't be your first step.

(1:53:41 - 1:53:45)

No. You wouldn't say what is the most risky thing. I mean, I'm exaggerating.

(1:53:45 - 1:53:51)

But you would say, well, what's the sensitive thing? The rest of that story. Right. That all sounds great.

(1:53:51 - 1:54:00)

The rest of that story is... You hated your flavor? She didn't like the thing, right? So we left and then she didn't like it. Okay, it's only mine for the next time. No, no.

(1:54:00 - 1:54:10)

Then she ate yours? No, then she ate mine, right? And then I'm stuck. I'm forced to eat this thing that I don't like. It's all very well.

(1:54:11 - 1:54:18)

That's the yin and yang. Yeah, the yin and yang. When I think of marriage, I feel like it has worked so well.

(1:54:19 - 1:54:39)

In a certain way, it's a great way to ensure against loneliness and always have attention and validation, the concept of family. Because you don't get the peaks and the troughs, but you get a little bit every day. I'm trying to think.

(1:54:40 - 1:54:59)

I mean, I, without question, could not function if we weren't married. In terms of professionally function, not just personally. Because I can't imagine doing all the things that I've had to do on my own.

(1:55:01 - 1:55:17)

So, to your point, loneliness, not just in a social companionship perspective, which I actually, I mean, that's nice, but it's much deeper than that. It's like having this, you know, people talk about life partner, whatever the word you want to use. It's called soulmate, for sure.

(1:55:17 - 1:55:26)

There's this partnership, but I'm not even trying to get to that bit. I think, actually, almost more practical. I think that there is that, and that is obviously wonderful.

(1:55:27 - 1:55:46)

But the slightly more practical aspect of it is someone who you can share these very difficult

things with, and who can support you when you need it. Or not just support, I think it brings out the best in you. Yeah, you know, and sees you in a way that not everyone sees.

(1:55:46 - 1:56:08)

And where the sum is greater than the parts, right? So, certainly, that is particularly acute, I think, for everybody. But, you know, if you're in one of these very high-pressure situations, you can't do that on your own. Well, I certainly could not have done it on my own.

(1:56:09 - 1:56:15)

Who's not your therapist. Yeah, maybe these days you could be a therapist, but that's not the same. For me, it's a bit like that.

(1:56:16 - 1:56:46)

A bit tricky if you're prime minister. But I'll tell you the counter to that, right? So, we have together faced ups and downs, while staying true to who we are, etc. But, like, one of the criticisms I've faced is, well, what's your identity, right? Because, as you rightly said, you know, you're your father's daughter or your husband's wife.

(1:56:46 - 1:57:35)

And so, it's got me thinking, you know, what's identity about? How do you define yourself? And is it based on where you live? What language you speak? What you eat? But we're saying you're different, right? And, you know, lately I've been getting a lot of pushback on my accent, right? You grew up in Bangalore, you've grown up here. What is this? Do you have a British accent? Do you understand any of that? I don't. We don't say anything to the youth.

(1:57:35 - 1:57:41)

We don't say anything. Even if they want something, they don't know. Say something now.

(1:57:42 - 1:57:50)

Just like being at home. Anyway. I'll come back to that accent thing in a second, actually.

(1:57:52 - 1:58:20)

Does Nicola speak more like your mum or dad? I would assume more like my dad. My sort of kind of dad, right? Yeah. So, where do you get your identity from? So, for me, my identity comes from genuinely having impact.

(1:58:20 - 1:59:00)

And I'll unpack that. So, it's how can I give to the communities in which I live? How can I stay true

to my values? How can I honour my heritage? And so, whatever we do professionally, even how we raise our children, I'm constantly thinking. I'm probably less worried than most about some of the more, I'm not going to use the word superficial, some of the more tangible concepts of identity, like what food we eat or what language we speak.

(1:59:01 - 1:59:04)

How you dress. Or how you dress. How I sound.

(1:59:09 - 1:59:39)

But staying true to your values, staying true to what matters most to you. You know, that's how I've defined, oh, thank you. That's how I've defined my identity versus it being trying to match someone else's or trying to meet societal expectations of what identity should be, right? And so, like with my accent, for example.

(1:59:40 - 1:59:57)

Actually, let's take a step back. You know, I remember Rishi and I came to India for the G20. And it was incredibly emotional for me, Nikhil, because I was coming to the place where I was raised.

(1:59:59 - 2:00:54)

I was coming to the place that defined my heritage, of which I'm very proud of. I was coming to a place that was my former home, but in a way representing a different home, right? So how do you handle that? And that really got me thinking about, well, in a scenario like this, who are you? Are you British or are you Indian? Are you neither or are you both? And it reminds me of what I think PM Modi said, I think in 2015, maybe when he was in the UK for that Wembley event. And he said, you know, the Indians who are living in the UK are all part of the living bridge, the Indian diaspora.

(2:00:58 - 2:01:13)

And they connect Britain to India and vice versa. And so I'm but one of the people living on this bridge, you know, the bridge that, you know, when you think of a bridge, it connects two places. It doesn't belong just to one place or the other.

(2:01:14 - 2:01:35)

So for me, when I think deeply about who I am in the context of current day, I am part of that living bridge. I feel incredibly at home in India. I am incredibly emotional about my I use the word emotional because it moves me.

(2:01:35 - 2:01:51)

My heritage, I'm incredibly proud of my heritage, my how I was raised. But I have also had these incredibly meaningful experiences in the UK. That's where we're raising our family.

(2:01:52 - 2:02:08)

And I am deeply committed to that community as well. So the things that I'm engaging in now and I'm doing them in areas that mean things to me. So in arts, culture, history, entrepreneurship, creativity.

(2:02:10 - 2:02:20)

These are areas that speak to me. And I'm constantly looking at how can I honor. Both these places and play a small role in bringing them together.

(2:02:21 - 2:02:33)

So long winded way is I'm very much a Bangalore girl with a British accent. You're not as big an RCB fan as me. Jainagar girl.

(2:02:34 - 2:02:44)

Jainagar girl, yes, yes, yes. We probably went to many of the same restaurants because we're similar age. Yeah, well, I still think you're quite a bit younger, but you know.

(2:02:44 - 2:02:49)

No, 39, 45. I know, I know, but it's like when you hit 40. Yeah, yeah, 80s.

(2:02:49 - 2:02:55)

MTR. MTR is not in Jainagar. MTR is more near Basavan Gudi, I think.

(2:02:55 - 2:03:02)

Okay, fine. Jainagar used to have. Which ones do you think are in Jainagar? I would say.

(2:03:03 - 2:03:05)

There's a place called Dosa Camp. Yes. In 4th block.

(2:03:05 - 2:03:12)

Yes, I remember the day it opened. They put everything in the dosa from mushrooms to baby corn. Yeah, cheese.

(2:03:12 - 2:03:16)

Whatever you can think of. Yeah, yeah. That ice cream place was presumably not there when you were growing up.

(2:03:16 - 2:03:19)

Corner house. Corner house, yes. We go there.

(2:03:20 - 2:03:25)

I used to eat. I had this thing called death by chocolate. Yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah.

(2:03:25 - 2:03:30)

They still have it. My kids had it two days ago. Adigaz was there back then? Adigaz was there.

(2:03:30 - 2:03:41)

I can't remember where exactly it was. I think the first time I came, your dad thought I should have this Indo-Chinese food. Yeah, I mean, that's all.

(2:03:42 - 2:03:46)

Yeah. You guys live near that park, right? Near the ground. Yeah.

(2:03:46 - 2:03:49)

Not park, ground. Yeah, ground. I used to go there to play cricket.

(2:03:49 - 2:03:53)

Yeah. Yeah. I have played cricket there.

(2:03:53 - 2:03:57)

Yeah? On my first trip. Less now. But when I used to come.

(2:03:58 - 2:04:13)

Can you get by in India without security and stuff like that? You know, it is the most incredible thing when I'm here because people are so kind. They are so welcoming. They're so supportive.

(2:04:15 - 2:04:29)

And it is humbling every time. So I do as best job I can as trying to talk to as many people as possible and say thank you to them and chat with them. So it's a wonderful and overwhelming experience every time.

(2:04:29 - 2:04:35)

Well, you make us look very good. I hope you keep winning and doing better. No, it's good.

(2:04:36 - 2:04:45)

We love it. It's been a great week at the summit. Now that I'm a bit freer, it's nice because we can be here more often.

(2:04:46 - 2:04:53)

I've been in India almost every few months for the past year. It's been really lovely. And we've been home.

(2:04:54 - 2:05:00)

We've taken the kids on different places. They saw Taj Mahal last year for the first time. I've done lots of work things here.

(2:05:00 - 2:05:08)

And then the cricket. I've been in Bombay for cricket with your dad. We went to the IPL final.

(2:05:08 - 2:05:15)

So it's been great. We did the Jaipur Literary Festival last year. So now we're getting a chance to enjoy a bit more of all these things.

(2:05:15 - 2:05:29)

I'm going to ask you another selfish question. I think a big motive I have, I'm using myself as the placeholder, but I think a lot more young people need to participate in politics. I think you're like testament to that.

(2:05:30 - 2:06:12)

I think it's a great thing in society and more needs to happen. When you become a politician and you see these really big problems, I'll be a little specific to England and that use case, but say fixing the NHS, reducing debt, reducing inflation. For somebody sitting on the outside, a young guy who wants to be in politics, when you go in and try to fix these problems, how hard is it? Is it that one person can actually change stuff? Lots of thoughts.

(2:06:12 - 2:06:26)

So I think if you want to do it, you need to have resilience. You need to have patience and you need to be driven by service rather than ambition. You need resilience because it is unforgiving.

(2:06:26 - 2:06:45)

In this day and age with social media, you need to have thick skin. We've talked all about how you cope with failure, but just coping with the day-to-day criticism, you have to be able to deal with that. Partly the best way to deal with it, by the way, is not to engage with a lot of it because we're all human.

(2:06:45 - 2:07:09)

You can have the thickest skin in the world, we're all human, but you do need that resilience. You need patience because I'll come to this in a second, things take longer than you would think, certainly longer than the private sector. And all politicians, if we're being honest, are motivated by both ambition and duty in public service.

(2:07:09 - 2:07:17)

I think every politician, being honest, they're both. Personal ambition? Yes, personal ambition. If we're being honest, I certainly am.

(2:07:17 - 2:07:36)

Most politicians, they're motivated by both. You just need to know where you sit on that scale. And if you are overly weighted towards personal ambition, I think you will not be successful, people will see through it, and you won't... Have that impact.

(2:07:36 - 2:08:01)

You won't be able to do the things that are necessary to succeed. So I think those are the three preconditions for getting involved. Then I'll answer your other question about can young people do it or how do they think about change? There's some things that I think some, not all, but some young people misunderstand about how to bring about change.

(2:08:02 - 2:08:17)

And I think one is there's this kind of almost cinematic notion that change happens in a moment. It's a speech. You have to remember we've grown up on movies which one guy becomes the prime minister for a day and fixes the country.

(2:08:17 - 2:08:24)

That's it. Great story. And change is less about a moment.

(2:08:24 - 2:08:37)

It's more about a movement. It takes time. And the other thing is voice matters, but change

comes about through participation.

(2:08:38 - 2:08:53)

And again, there's this romantic notion that change comes about because you're the outsider, the rebel, the disruptor. Actually, the change happens more because people become part of the process. They become part of the institutions.

(2:08:53 - 2:09:05)

They change from the inside through a period of time and hard work. And that's what I try and get across to young people. That's for the most part how substantive change happens.

(2:09:06 - 2:09:36)

It happens when you decide to come inside and be part of the process and take the time to bring it about. The kind of romantic cinematic notion that it can happen from the outside, being the disruptor with one speech or amazing protest, it works in the movies. I think it's less about real life, which is why young people should, if they do want to change things for the better, do it through government and come into public service and come into politics to bring it about.

(2:09:36 - 2:09:52)

Come into politics and then do what? Convince other politicians? Sorry? Convince other politicians. I think, let me give you an example I use. Because people say, oh, you can only have change if you become prime minister and everyone gets to become prime minister.

(2:09:52 - 2:10:05)

And I say that's not true. And the example I give young people who are thinking about becoming an MP is of a guy called William Wilberforce. And he was an MP in Yorkshire, same as me.

(2:10:05 - 2:10:24)

And my predecessor as a member of parliament wrote a beautiful biography about him. Now, William Wilberforce was someone who essentially abolished the slave trade in the UK and then internationally and then helped abolish slavery. He was never a cabinet member, let alone prime minister or chancellor.

(2:10:25 - 2:10:51)

He made a decision to do it only as a backbench MP because he believed that would give him the freedom and the moral authority and the time to focus on this one thing. He also had patience. From the first time he entered parliament and made a speech about it, it took 20 years for him to get a bill passed in parliament to abolish the slave trade and then another 20-odd years

to have parliament declare that slavery itself was illegal.

(2:10:52 - 2:11:06)

And then he died three days after that. So his career on this issue spanned 40 years, of which the big meaningful, the first meaningful thing happened after 20. And during that period, all the things that we've been talking about, he had to cope with failure.

(2:11:06 - 2:11:40)

Parliament voted more than 10 times no, no, no, no, no. But like we discussed earlier, if everybody has to have the incentive of personal ambition being met, how do I incentivise a young guy who will only find that personal ambition being met if he sits in a position of power? Well, well, then this goes back to what we were saying before. There are lots of different ways to make a difference in life.

(2:11:40 - 2:11:52)

There are lots of different ways to have impact. But if you want to have impact on that scale, the best way to do it is through government or through the political process. And that's what I'm saying.

(2:11:52 - 2:12:04)

But even though I'm saying you need to do it through that, we don't need to, but the best way to do it is through the political process. It doesn't mean you have to be, you know, the prime minister or in the cabinet. What I'd say is there are hundreds of members of parliament.

(2:12:05 - 2:12:20)

That is a different bar to becoming the prime minister. But this individual, William Wilberforce, as one of 600 odd members, however many it was in those days, hundreds of members of parliament, was able to bring about this very significant change. And he didn't do it on his own either.

(2:12:21 - 2:12:26)

He touches on what we were saying before. He built a movement around him. Other people played their part.

(2:12:26 - 2:12:37)

Now he was the person at the front. But I think it's a really instructive story for young people to read. And I was inspired by it, because I didn't know I was going to end up in cabinet or be prime minister.

(2:12:38 - 2:12:55)

But it was, you know, as well as what Akshatha's dad said to me, it was a great story of how one person, you say one person, it takes more than one person, of course, as a team. But, you know, this was one person who made it his mission to do it. And it goes back to what you said earlier, Nikhil, about different motivations being complementary.

(2:12:55 - 2:13:03)

And Akshatha was talking about this. He had a moral view that slavery was wrong. And that's what motivated him.

(2:13:03 - 2:13:19)

And he was a person of faith. But he was smart, right? And he recognized that wasn't the best way to persuade everyone. And actually, he came up with an economic case as to why slavery was wrong.

(2:13:19 - 2:13:34)

And he came up with a patriotic security case why the slave trade was wrong, because Britain was in a war with France. And he was saying, well, people are giving slaves to French, they'll be able to come and beat Britain, so we should bang the trade. And he was clever that way, right? So for him, it was a moral mission.

(2:13:34 - 2:13:46)

But ultimately, he knew some people would be motivated by different things. So he was able to bring all of that to bear. And ultimately, as I said, have the patience, have the resilience, the storytelling that we talked about.

(2:13:47 - 2:14:07)

But based actually oddly as well, he was a great orator. You and I are talking about learning from that. But there was another guy called Thomas Clarkson who did all the hard work of documenting what was happening in these camps, in the slave plantations, on the boats where people were being traded, which was awful.

(2:14:07 - 2:14:30)

And just painstakingly documented all this detail and hard work, which ultimately then became part of these stories. So I think it's a really powerful way to illustrate how change comes about, how politics is the best way, parliamentary processes are the best way to bring about massive change, but also illustrating that you don't need to be the prime minister or in the cabinet to do it.

Totally agree.

(2:14:30 - 2:14:59)

But I think maybe Nikhil, what you're getting at is what kind of people should go into politics? Who should get into politics? No, I'm thinking for our audience, like the people you're speaking to are young, Indian wannabe entrepreneurs. If I have to convince one of them to become a politician, I need to meet their need for validation and their personal ambition need both. I'm trying to put something in each box.

(2:14:59 - 2:15:22)

In the validation and ambition box. But I don't think they need to give up being an entrepreneur. We talked about before, I think people are more effective as politicians or in government having brought that experience into parliament with them or into government with them.

(2:15:22 - 2:15:34)

So for the people listening, I would say, go build your business. You're going to learn an extraordinary amount. But I'm figuring how to trigger them to enter politics today.

(2:15:35 - 2:15:46)

After they've built the business or right now? Right now. Well, do they need to? Yeah. Why do they need to do it today? This is the thing.

(2:15:46 - 2:15:56)

I mean, sure, some people might want to. My personal bias is for people to do something else first. And this goes back to what we were saying before.

(2:15:57 - 2:16:03)

There's this rush, rush, rush. Build your business. Why? Because it will give you that validation that you want.

(2:16:04 - 2:16:21)

And skills. And set of practical skills and financial security and independence. And my word, what an incredible platform that is to then enter politics, where you have so much more understanding and self-awareness of who you are.

(2:16:21 - 2:16:42)

You've already got that validation, which means you'll enter the political arena with so much more personal self-confidence. The resilience of having had the ups and downs of building a business

and doing something and then using that experience to benefit the country. But that motivation has to be one where you are getting into it because you want to make your country a better place.

(2:16:43 - 2:16:57)

That has to be at the core of it, right? I think that's okay to be ambitious about it. That is true for many, many young people. But what I'm trying to also see is for a country where the average age is 28, we need more people who are 28 in parliament.

(2:16:58 - 2:17:09)

Look, I can see that. I can see that overall. My point about as an individual, I think you're better off having the experience.

(2:17:09 - 2:17:24)

I can see if everyone does that and then nobody is in parliament at a young age. I can see that. But maybe, Rish, it comes back to that passion thing, which you were saying so eloquently about William Wilberforce, right? I don't know the history, so pardon me.

(2:17:25 - 2:17:30)

He entered parliament at 28. Right. Thank you.

(2:17:30 - 2:18:01)

He had this deep-seated passion for abolishing slavery. That mattered more to him than anything else. And in a country as large as India, where you said the average age is 28, I am sure there are young people or 28-year-olds who there are at least some 28-year-olds who will have these moral missions.

(2:18:03 - 2:18:18)

There will be. But they don't need to, this is again what we were saying before, they don't need to just have some moral or social mission. It's a great mission if someone is listening to you but cares passionately about entrepreneurship.

(2:18:19 - 2:18:39)

Then that's not necessarily a social outcome. But going into parliament to make sure that India is a fantastic country for entrepreneurs, to encourage all the people listening to you to grow their businesses. They may not make the money in entrepreneurship.

(2:18:40 - 2:18:52)

But they're passionate about entrepreneurship and they recognize that entrepreneurship is important to India succeeding. Go into parliament and be the champion for that. Be the champion for small business, for example.

(2:18:52 - 2:19:03)

What does it mean to make India, India is already a very vibrant entrepreneurial ecosystem but we can all get better. But that can be your passion. It doesn't have to be, it's fine, there will be some people who have a more social classic.

(2:19:03 - 2:19:17)

You're right, I agree. We're also leaning into who we are, right? Because I'm kind of thinking altruism. But I think for lots of people who are entrepreneurial minded or technology minded, those things can be put to incredible positive good for India.

(2:19:18 - 2:19:43)

So you can be excited and passionate about those areas and think actually, well, I'm going to use politics as the vehicle to make sure India and Indians prosper when it comes to technology, when it comes to entrepreneurship. That can be your mission in parliament. And the validation comes from, I mean, you'll speak better than me, but if you can get some kind of law passed, that makes it easier.

(2:19:43 - 2:20:08)

There's lots of different ways. For small businesses to be incorporated, that makes it easier for, not to get into controversial topics, but social media to be regulated, whatever it is, right? When you do one thing, when you contribute to changing one clause and one law that's passing parliament that will unlock something special for entrepreneurs or technologists, for the rest of your life, you will have done that for 1.4 billion people. It's a pretty big fact.

(2:20:08 - 2:20:16)

I mean, you're talking about people want validation. Sure, it's great to have a company in a unicorn IPO. That is great.

(2:20:17 - 2:20:29)

Changing a law that is going to impact 1.4 billion people and how your country progresses, think about the compounding benefit of that. Sure, that value doesn't accrue to you personally. The monetary value doesn't.

(2:20:29 - 2:20:37)

And that's where the service bit comes in. Right, that's where you have to be motivated. The societal value is not in the unicorn billion here, hundred million here.

(2:20:37 - 2:20:48)

It's in the hundreds and hundreds of millions. Or the millions and millions. I'm excited to be 28 and going to politics now.

(2:20:49 - 2:20:57)

There are some, you know. You know the guy in our constituency? South Bangalore, he's quite young. Oh, is he? Yes, his name is... Tejasi.

(2:20:58 - 2:21:13)

Friend of mine, he's a young chap. The other reason that people should think about it is... Notwithstanding everything I said before about experience and everything else. It's differentiating.

(2:21:13 - 2:21:29)

If you are one of very few young people, you are differentiated in politics. Public adoration is a big point of validation, which does come with being a politician. I think that is different in different countries.

(2:21:30 - 2:21:33)

That's a tricky path. Yeah, that is in different countries. Maybe more so here.

(2:21:34 - 2:21:50)

Thank you. Because in lots of places in the West, it's quite unforgiving. The day-to-day experience of most politicians is hard, right? Because of things like social media and the criticism and things like that.

(2:21:51 - 2:21:56)

It can be very rewarding and fulfilling. Of course it can be. But it's not every day.

(2:21:57 - 2:22:07)

It's like a... Or sunshine and rainbows. It comes back to what I wrote about in my Stanford Business School essay. And in fact, I did write about this.

(2:22:07 - 2:22:22)

The solution is education. So here's what I mean. You know, when you think of a society and how

it progresses, there are many different ways.

(2:22:23 - 2:23:00)

But you want to make sure that the society that you live in, the government of the land, of the nation, provides sufficient security so that the basic needs are met, right? Now, I know that isn't always easy, but that's sort of the focus. And then you think, well, okay, then how can we progress as a society? And to me, the answer is education. Because education, in my mind, is one of the things that allows equality of opportunity to emerge.

(2:23:01 - 2:23:11)

In a way, has that been solved for? Because education has gotten democratized with internet and AI and all of that. Like I never went to college. I can choose to pick a book I like to read and read it.

(2:23:12 - 2:23:20)

It's not that expensive. Yeah, but that's because you're fundamentally curious. So I define education more broadly, right? But Nikhil's point is right.

(2:23:20 - 2:23:30)

And I was talking about it at the summit. It's one of the, to me, one of the incredible things that AI can do. It isn't just about raising the ceiling.

(2:23:31 - 2:23:50)

It can lift the floor for humanity. And the most obvious ways it can do that are democratizing access to health care and education. Where you've got, now it is possible that before too long, every single child will be able to have the best possible teacher for them.

(2:23:50 - 2:24:18)

And that's the job of philanthropy, of government, of different organizations to enable those outcomes, right? So yes, any child who lives in a certain society should have access to what I think is a broad sense of education. Of course, that's letters and numbers, but it's also curiosity. It's problem thinking skills.

(2:24:18 - 2:24:58)

Because when you have that in your toolkit, that's when you create entrepreneurs, you create innovation, you create wealth in so many different ways. And then the tax is kind of the next step. But I think how do we first create that equality of opportunity so that more people are able to create that wealth in the first place? But even with education, barring the risk capital, if asset

prices continue to inflate at the pace that they are, it'll be very hard for the inequality to come down.

(2:24:58 - 2:25:23)

I met this interesting guy, Michael Milken. He spent a lot of money and time coming up with this plan where he wants to give every child who's born a certain amount of equity. Exactly.

So that's what I was just going to say. Equity in the beginning. I mean, look, this is your old life, right? But trying to give more people a stake in the system, a financial stake, is a good thing.

(2:25:23 - 2:25:29)

I think even the U.S. is considering this. The U.S. is going down this line. Is Michael Dell doing something along those lines? Michael Dell has helped part fund some of it.

(2:25:29 - 2:25:57)

Some of the work that motivates our charity in the U.K. that we've set up, the Richmond Project, which is around numeracy, is because if people have better, stronger number skills, then they can be more financially literate. The research from Stanford actually tells us some of these foundational skills you need to understand are inflation and compounding. They are two fundamental things that lots of people do not understand.

(2:25:57 - 2:26:19)

And if they don't, that inequality will widen. Because if you understand those things, then you recognize that inflation erodes the purchasing power. And if you understand the power of compound interest or compounding in general, and you understand that when you're young, those two things, of course, talk to this point, you need to have had a good education to have a decent job.

(2:26:19 - 2:26:26)

But you need to then think with your, I need to save, right? There is an element of saving. This is how I should save. This is why I need to save.

(2:26:26 - 2:26:32)

That compounds over time. That's what we need to do more of. Otherwise, that gap will keep growing.

(2:26:32 - 2:26:39)

Maybe I should take education back and say learning. Being curious. How do you teach someone

to be curious? Yeah.

(2:26:40 - 2:27:06)

I have to think about that. Yeah. Michael Milken had this interesting thought that if you start somebody off with, say, I don't know, $1,000 in an S&P index fund, like ETF, psychologically, them knowing that they have something, something to lose, psychologically changes behavior significantly, more than the cost of the $1,000.

(2:27:07 - 2:27:36)

I think there's probably something to that. Our way of contributing to that is through giving people the confidence they need with numbers, and therefore financial literacy, so they know what to do with it, right? And even if not, everyone is going to be able to be given the $1,000, right? So you need the people who are able to save to recognize they should save, how to save, that it's worth their while saving. So, look, I'm a big believer in that.

(2:27:36 - 2:27:56)

Your point is interesting on curiosity, because we talk about that a lot. And I actually think there's slightly different things, because I was just very big on just being curious for the sake of being curious and trying to instill that in the kids. Learning for the sake of learning.

(2:27:56 - 2:28:21)

I'm a little bit more learn for a purpose, a bit practical applied. But I've come to realize that I think one of the most kind of compounding skills that you can develop is exactly this. We call it learnability, which is a little bit different from your curiosity, but they're linked.

(2:28:21 - 2:28:35)

And I just think about my own career, you know, it's traversed finance, government, technology policy. The compounding skill is being able to learn new things. And I think that is only going to be more relevant in this new world.

(2:28:35 - 2:28:44)

So when I talk to young people now, and I say, just learn how to learn. And that to me is education. So it's not about a degree.

(2:28:44 - 2:28:52)

It's not about a fixed point thing. Maybe the solution lies in what you said earlier. You brought up Greek philosophy.

(2:28:53 - 2:29:08)

Maybe AI will solve this problem as well, because in times of abundance, we go back to like the Greeks did in their time, philosophy and anthropology. It was an entire profession to sit and think about life. And that's, to me, is what makes us more human.

(2:29:09 - 2:29:18)

Maybe AI and productivity gains and abundance will get us to that point where everybody has more than enough. So then we can sit and think about that. Yeah.

(2:29:19 - 2:29:27)

Yeah. It's what was said in that, when you and Elon had that conversation. It's a very utopian view.

(2:29:27 - 2:29:45)

It is a very utopian way of the world. And until we get to that point, I think people's careers will keep changing. So this ability to keep learning new things, I think is an underestimated, very powerful quality to have.

(2:29:45 - 2:29:53)

How do you see AI in your lives? What do you use it for? Oh. Like the biggest use case. Biggest use case.

(2:29:54 - 2:30:02)

I mean, for me is research, right? I was going to say research. Just on different things. And likely Claude, because you're consulting with him.

(2:30:02 - 2:30:12)

Exactly. The Claude is what I use the most. Have you given Claude all the connectors, access and allowed him to... I'm starting to do that now.

(2:30:12 - 2:30:22)

I haven't yet. I've got this course that I'm about to do to start using it for... I want to start using it with Excel. I've given it a lot of access and now I'm worried.

(2:30:22 - 2:30:35)

Because I don't even go to my email inbox anymore because I've given it access to all my emails and chat and all of that. So I ask it, are there any important emails that I missed today? And it

saves me the time to scroll through. To scroll through.

(2:30:36 - 2:30:40)

Yeah. It's scary. It knows every word of every email.

(2:30:40 - 2:31:05)

So what we're just developing in the office is so it has access to... Well, actually, and Copilot. So we've just got Copilot as well. So because I want Copilot to be able to, in our office SharePoint, OneDrive, yeah, OneDrive, to be able to... Because it needs to know what we've done and what we've got so that it can build on it.

(2:31:05 - 2:31:16)

So that for us is quite important. So just getting that Copilot integration where it can go into the folder and I can say, look, here are all these things. Do X. That is what we're doing next.

(2:31:16 - 2:31:23)

I've never learned how to code. So on my... But now you don't need to. No, now I need to learn how to vibe code.

(2:31:23 - 2:31:27)

Yeah. Right. So I've got a video course that I'm about to start.

(2:31:27 - 2:31:37)

Can I tell you from somebody who went through it recently, I don't know anything about coding or programming. I hired this guy recently who spends an hour or two with me every day. Yeah.

(2:31:39 - 2:31:48)

And we were having these conversations and we started with CloudBot. Yeah. So this is a little bit... Now it's called OpenClaw, but... Yeah.

(2:31:49 - 2:32:13)

This is a little, I don't know, scary because you kind of like host it on a tiny... On this Mac mini, right? Yeah, and you give it access to everything. We have that. But the thing I realized about prompting is even when you use Cloud Code for the first time, like how specific you are while you prompt is a skill set in itself which I don't have.

(2:32:13 - 2:32:23)

So somebody said it really well. I was watching the interview of the guy who built CloudBot or OpenClaw now. He said it's like playing the piano.

(2:32:23 - 2:32:34)

You can't expect somebody to sit in front of the piano and prompt for the very first time or give up when you try to play for the very first time and not try again. You need like a few lessons. Yeah.

(2:32:35 - 2:32:39)

But it's not too many. I've done like maybe a month of lessons. That's about it.

(2:32:41 - 2:32:51)

It feels like there is that point where you cross that line, where you start to feel more comfortable with it. But I don't think it's week one. I think it's week three.

(2:32:51 - 2:32:55)

Yeah, no, I think it will take some time. It'll go to week one soon. Yeah, well, that will be good.

(2:32:56 - 2:33:23)

But that to me seems like an important new skill to develop. Yeah. It is perfectly plausible that I should be able to create software that will do certain, there's so many things that I do, and I'm starting to figure out, but I need someone to help me understand how do I think about all the things I do, which ones will lend themselves to being basically dealt with and then learn how to build the thing to do it.

(2:33:24 - 2:33:37)

So that is my next thing to do. But the thing actually, I mean, you do your thing as well, but we go back to education. That is the thing that I find it incredibly helpful at home.

(2:33:37 - 2:33:43)

Transformative, yeah. It's transformative to be able to teach our kids. I am not a good, she's an excellent teacher.

(2:33:44 - 2:33:49)

I'm not a good teacher. It's one thing to know something. It's a different thing to be able to explain it and teach others.

(2:33:50 - 2:33:57)

And impart it, yeah. But this is what I've always thought with schooling in college. I didn't go, I mean, it's natural that I take this perspective.

(2:33:58 - 2:34:05)

Yeah. But when you don't go to a formal institution, you can pick what books you want to read. Yeah.

(2:34:05 - 2:34:17)

Like structure takes that away. And I feel like in many ways it's a disadvantage. Which is a disadvantage? Like going to a structured institution and being told what to read and how to read.

(2:34:17 - 2:34:28)

It also depends on the personality, I think, a little bit. But now we're getting to... How self-motivated. I wasn't even talking about motivation as much as, like even between us, you like more structure.

(2:34:28 - 2:34:47)

I like less structure. Yeah, you respond better to... So I respond better when I don't have as many guardrails, right? Right. But if the entire education system is evolving to be a place where you come in, you interact with peers, but actually it's self-directed learning guided by AI.

(2:34:48 - 2:34:52)

Yeah. Then there's a different way to learn. Yeah.

(2:34:52 - 2:35:05)

And it probably would have suited you and been better that way, right? But helping our kids with learning. That's what I did the other week when you were away. Oh, yes.

(2:35:06 - 2:35:20)

But I've done that increasingly where I haven't... Our daughter had a physics test a couple of weeks ago. I haven't done any physics since I was 16. And I didn't know off the top of my head what she was doing.

(2:35:21 - 2:35:37)

But I popped the paper into Claude. It comes back with a question by question explanatory guide, so I can then help her. And then it created a revision booklet at the end that I could then use the next day to help her prep for the test.

(2:35:38 - 2:35:46)

If that wasn't there, it would have been a right pain to try and do. And I saw that. And then I see them and we see our kids.

(2:35:46 - 2:35:55)

We've encouraged them to use it, but we've tried to say to them and supervise it. We say, look, it's got to help you think. It can't do the thinking for you.

(2:35:55 - 2:36:03)

It can explain things to you so you learn. But you need to have done the thinking. Especially when they're young.

(2:36:03 - 2:36:14)

One discipline I have is I never use AI to write. Yeah? Nope. And it's old fashioned.

I get it. On pen and paper? No, meaning... Type. I type, yeah.

(2:36:14 - 2:36:21)

But I just can't do that. I just can't do it. And what do you write about now? Whatever I'm writing about.

(2:36:21 - 2:36:48)

Currently I'm involved in arts and culture and doing some storytelling around cultural institutions in the UK. I'm doing some work around fashion, entrepreneurship and business. I use Google for research.

(2:36:49 - 2:36:59)

But I'll tell you where I use... I'm starting to think with AI. But I don't use Claude or anyone else to help me write. Right? Like the thesis of any argument, I write myself.

(2:37:00 - 2:37:44)

Even the speeches, et cetera, I write them all up. But what I've been fascinated is... Again, as someone who's on the outside, can AI be creative? And what then is even creativity, right? For a long time in the early days of this whole evolution of AI, people would say, well, AI can code faster than you solve mathematical problems, et cetera, but it can't be creative. And so I've been amazed how I can have philosophical discussions with Claude.

(2:37:45 - 2:38:09)

And it will come up with the most creative, thoughtful answers. I mean, amazing. What is creative in your view? Is it contrarian behavior that's creative? No, putting multiple thoughts together, right? Not just giving me a list of facts or kind of obvious answers, but connecting the dots.

(2:38:10 - 2:38:51)

Pulling not facts, but also even emotion. I would, in a way, in the new world, define creativity by contrarian behavior more so than yesterday, because a lot of these models are trained on data which always projects a certain path. Yes, that's right.

Yeah, yeah, yeah. Because they're trained on a stock of knowledge and information. This is, I guess, how will they be able to come up with something new? You used to manage money before politics.

(2:38:51 - 2:39:26)

Yes, I used to be an investor. As a fund manager, I'm guessing you researched a whole bunch of industries and stocks. After becoming a politician, did you realize there's an information arbitrage that is still at play that makes one fund manager better than another? What did you believe as a fund manager that you became a politician and got access to everything and you were like, this is stupid? You know, I didn't ever think about it like that.

(2:39:27 - 2:39:47)

The similarity I found between politics and fund management was this concept of the noise of the market. So the investing I did was always fundamental, long-term investing, like Warren Buffett. And he has this whole mantra about ignoring the short-term noise of the market and quarterly earnings.

(2:39:47 - 2:39:56)

He hasn't done very well in the last decade, I would like to say. I haven't seen the numbers for a while. But over his career, it's a pretty incredible track record.

(2:39:56 - 2:40:03)

I think he did well when information arbitrage was more at play. I saw that article. I saw someone had done that analysis.

(2:40:03 - 2:40:17)

I haven't gone into it in detail. I mean, I always found him, his letters, his approach to investing, I'm a total devotee and disciple of. I've been to Omaha for the shareholder meeting, etc.

(2:40:23 - 2:40:37)

But the similarity was there. You have the politics, it's got lots of the day-to-day noise, media, social media, this, that, and the other. And I always tried to, helpful reminder from your investing days to focus on the long-term fundamentals of what you're doing.

(2:40:37 - 2:40:59)

I found that quite a helpful analogy. On the information arbitrage, I don't know if that's... I didn't necessarily see that. I mean, it wasn't as if... Clearly, if you're involved in making decisions in government, you have access to information, which is why you clearly should not be trading.

(2:40:59 - 2:41:15)

That should be illegal and is illegal. But beyond that, I'm not sure I saw. Because largely, what's happening in the political process is, it's commented on, it's in the news, there's a million people talking about it.

(2:41:15 - 2:41:41)

So it's perfectly possible for people to figure out the dynamics of a policy as it's going through parliament or something like that. That was my general sense of it. But the other thing from the investing side of it is, I mean, this thing about long-run and short-run.

(2:41:42 - 2:42:13)

And I thought that was... Because what gave us, or my type of investing an advantage was that focus on the long-term, right? So you could... And if you had capital that allowed you to take a long-term view, you could ignore the short-term volatility of things, confident that over time, the fundamentals and the valuation would align. That was interesting, because you saw what happened in the financial crisis. And obviously, you try and do the right thing in the long-term.

(2:42:13 - 2:42:34)

But really, the short-term, someone put it very well. They said the long-term is really just a succession of short-terms that you either survived or were not kicked out of. And actually, I realized over time, there isn't, at least in politics, maybe it's more broadly in business, there's less of a conflict between the short-term and the long-term.

(2:42:34 - 2:42:48)

They're really just... They all fit into a nested time frame. And I think as long as your short-term actions need to be consistent with your long-term direction, is what you want. It's not that you can't do things in the short-term.

(2:42:49 - 2:43:11)

It's just that your weekly rhythm has to align with your one-year plan, which aligns with your three-year strategy, with your five-year vision. Those things have to be consistent and have a consistency and a connection to them. The problem is when you have this tension between short-term and long-term is when the short-term goal or short-term thing you're doing is misaligned with the long-term direction.

(2:43:11 - 2:43:30)

But it's wrong to ignore the short-term. The other analogy is you need to do the minimum to survive in the short-term so that you can be around to benefit in the long-term. So in the financial sense, if you don't have the liquidity in the short-term, then you might be right in the long-term, but you'll be out of business.

(2:43:30 - 2:43:51)

So in that financial sense, if you're levered or you don't have capital that is secure... And in politics, you need to do enough in the short-term to earn the right to be there over time. So you can't just kind of head in the sand and say, look, this will all work out in five years. Come and see me then.

(2:43:51 - 2:44:10)

You need to be delivering enough things in the short-term that are consistent with the long-run goal to kind of allow you to survive to make that long-run argument. So I think in both cases, you have to recognize the kind of connection between the short-term and the long-term. You can't exclude the short-term and just say, I'm focused on the long-term.

(2:44:10 - 2:44:17)

You guys like chocolate? Yes. Okay. I told you, you can always count on Rishi to eat.

(2:44:17 - 2:44:30)

I'm very full, but I will always make a bit of space for some chocolate. Will you ask Hari Om chocolate? Okay, last part of today. I'm going to ask you both one question to finish it off.

(2:44:30 - 2:44:37)

I don't know what the time is. What is the time? How are we doing? Oh gosh, 10 o'clock. We've done well.

(2:44:39 - 2:44:45)

It's been a few hours. Yes. Okay, last part of today.

(2:44:45 - 2:45:06)

One question to both of you. To Rishi, if you had to, today after knowing... Okay, let me preface this question by saying we spoke about you coming into the position of Prime Minister. How was it to lose that position? What did you learn from it? Same question for both? No, different one.

(2:45:08 - 2:45:16)

What's your question for her? There you go. Okay, let me do Akshita first and we'll come back to you. Yeah, no.

(2:45:19 - 2:45:37)

Somebody said, in the end, civilizations perish because they listen to the politicians a lot more than they listen to their voice. Shall I go? You have time. So are you saying do I agree or disagree? Yeah.

(2:45:37 - 2:45:48)

Do you want me to go? I do mine. Sure, go. So we've talked about failure a couple of times through this.

(2:45:52 - 2:46:07)

Failure in that way is very hard. When you lose an election, it's hard because it is public. I mean, it's extremely public.

(2:46:07 - 2:46:32)

It comes at the end of a very grueling, intense period of a campaign, which is pretty unforgiving. And because it's public, you're failing in front of your friends and your family. And you have a lot of responsibility for the other members of your party who, as a result of that loss, are no longer MPs.

(2:46:32 - 2:46:44)

So their livelihoods, their job, the thing that gives them purpose is gone. And in many cases, that is not to do with the personal job that they have done. Don't give me chocolate.

(2:46:45 - 2:46:51)

Don't have that. That's just like a protein thing, which is pretending to be healthy. That's your breakfast.

(2:46:51 - 2:46:57)

We need chocolate. Okay, here we go. You know, it is hard.

(2:47:01 - 2:47:23)

I'd be lying if I didn't say it wasn't hard. And it takes some time to recover from. But then, for me, what got me through that period, including that bit, was just remembering why I did it.

(2:47:27 - 2:47:51)

That weekend, when we talked about it, just before I became Prime Minister, that situation was very tough. Inflation was at a 10-year high. My party was 36 points behind in the polls, just in this leadership thing.

(2:47:54 - 2:48:20)

And if you were just motivated by ambition and about winning and losing and position, then you would never have taken the job in the first place. I did the job because I felt at that moment it was my duty, because I was better placed to, or I was well-placed to make a difference for the country at a difficult time. And that's what we talked about that weekend.

(2:48:20 - 2:48:36)

That's why I did it, knowing that it was going to be very tough. And when that finality of the tough moment came, it wasn't that it was any... It wasn't any easier in that moment. It wasn't any easier, but with the time, you're able to remember why you did it.

(2:48:37 - 2:48:56)

And how you did it. And to be able to look yourself in the mirror and say, that was my dharma, that was my job, that was my duty to do this, to do it to the best of my ability, and to focus on that. And as the Gita says, you don't enjoy the fruits and the outcomes, you focus on doing your duty.

(2:48:56 - 2:49:16)

And that is what ultimately gave me the strength to go through it, and the strength to cope with the failure after it. And then in the fullness of time, we talked about this as well. It's important to draw the right stories from one's failure, if you are going to grow from them.

(2:49:16 - 2:49:35)

Because life is full of ups and downs in all walks of life. And you've got to use the failures and the setbacks to grow. So, and actually this helped me with this over time, is looking back on that overall period and making sure that I'm able to take away the things that I need to learn from it.

(2:49:35 - 2:49:49)

And not the whole thing, treat it as if I was some victim, and just be filled with self-pity. Because if that's how you feel, you won't take any good lessons from it. And you won't grow as an individual.

(2:49:49 - 2:50:14)

So that to me is how I got through, it's how it felt, which was not easy for all those reasons. How I dealt with it, and then hopefully how you can turn it into something that actually helps you in life, rather than holds you back. Is it easy to go going back to be a corporate after all of this? You're still an MP.

(2:50:14 - 2:50:22)

Well, I'm still in parliament. And so that is my anchor and my foundation. It's where I get my fulfillment from week in, week out.

(2:50:22 - 2:50:32)

It's actually, it's enjoyable. It's enjoyable being in parliament and not being the person at the dispatch box having to deal with the problem sometimes. It's actually nice to be able to ask the question.

(2:50:32 - 2:50:46)

I'm enjoying that as well. And in the future, is that what you will pursue, politics? Yeah, as we talked about earlier, the future, who knows which direction it's going to take us in. Near future, yes? I mean, the near future, that's where I am.

(2:50:46 - 2:50:59)

I'm in parliament and staying in parliament. And, you know, I've got, as we said, hope for touchwood, 20 years ahead of me. And so for the first time in a long time, I don't have an immediate thing that I'm gunning for.

(2:50:59 - 2:51:10)

So we'll see where the future goes. But this goes back to the adaptability point we talked about. My own career is one where I've gone from finance and investing to politics and government.

(2:51:11 - 2:51:22)

Now I'm spending more time in technology. This ability to adapt, to learn, to grow, that is the key trait. And I don't know what the next chapter is going to be.

(2:51:22 - 2:51:30)

It could be back to one of these. It could be something completely different. Who knows? But you've just got to be able to keep learning and adapting.

(2:51:30 - 2:51:42)

And it's not just learning about new things, but learning from your failures so that you can hopefully succeed to higher heights on the next thing you do. Being curious about your failures. That's the point.

(2:51:42 - 2:51:58)

The story that you tell yourself about why things didn't work is really important. And it's easy not to be curious enough about it and to assume you were the victim of circumstance. You have to be more... Balanced.

(2:51:58 - 2:52:04)

Yeah. You can't say it's all my fault, but equally you can't say it's all someone else's fault. That's the balance.

(2:52:05 - 2:52:09)

Middle ground again. Yeah, the middle path. You have to do that.

(2:52:09 - 2:52:25)

So that is how I've... Thank you. Before we go to Akshuta, there's a brand called Sabko which... This particular coffee bean is from Kerala, but there's a bunch from Karnataka, which I will send you. You just tell me the name, I will get it.

(2:52:25 - 2:52:30)

They make really good chocolates. And this is coffee bean, is it? Yeah. No, cacao.

(2:52:30 - 2:52:34)

Oh, cacao bean. That one has walnut in it. That's walnut.

(2:52:34 - 2:52:36)

And this is really dark. If you like dark chocolates. Very nice.

(2:52:36 - 2:52:44)

She prefers very dark chocolates. Both lovely. So your question... Poets, politicians.

(2:52:44 - 2:53:09)

We listen more to our politicians than our poets, and it's a problem. Yeah, yeah. So, prior to Rishi doing his job at No.

10, I would have probably said poets, because this is how I used to... how I have defined poets in the past. Idealist. Emotional.

(2:53:10 - 2:53:17)

Emotionally driven. People who can move with words. Words are very important to me.

(2:53:17 - 2:53:30)

It's part of... I would say it's how I've grown up through reading and writing and being moved by words and storytelling. Indeed, they break the Stanford Business School class into poets and quants. I was a quant.

(2:53:31 - 2:53:36)

Actually, I was a poet. Yes. So I would have said poets.

(2:53:36 - 2:53:55)

I'm not saying today I won't say poets. The answer is more nuanced today. It also depends on how you define a politician, right? You can take one definition as people who say one thing, do something else.

(2:53:55 - 2:54:07)

People who are inherently obsessed with power. Sadly, in some cases, there's corruption involved. There's all these negative connotations.

(2:54:09 - 2:54:31)

But I... I think, and I know I'm married to Rishi and I'm biased. Of course, I agree with that. But I think there are people like you, Rish, who can do it with a great deal of integrity and who can bring about that impact at scale and do it with integrity.

(2:54:32 - 2:55:08)

And I think those people need... Those people are needed in the political world. And I am optimistic that we will find, and there already are, and there will be more people like that who will approach politics as their purpose, who will be driven by passion for impact, and who will get their validation because they can change people's lives for the better. So I think today I would say both

poets and politicians.

(2:55:09 - 2:55:27)

That is a good encapsulation of our journey because we've gone, if you ask me, it's what we learn from each other, right? And actually, we spoke about it in the Stanford speech. You know, when we first met, Akshita was very passionate about making a difference and saving the world. Incredibly idealistic.

(2:55:28 - 2:55:55)

And I think one of the things that you got from me was actually understanding that's all very well having the idealism. How do you channel that into outcome? And actually, as we were talking, how do you bring about change? The political process in government is not the only way, but it's the way to do it at the biggest scale. And if you'd ask me, funnily enough, I have probably moved in the other direction over time.

(2:55:56 - 2:56:08)

All the things we've been talking about when we were talking about what classes you should take at Stanford and how I've changed my approach over time. I think I need to become more poetic. Probably.

(2:56:08 - 2:56:29)

And it's the lesson I... I think if I... The thing that I don't do enough of, which I wish I did, and I wish I did over time, is not reading poetry, but reading fiction. So I'm someone who just... People like me, I think, in general, but I read just nonfiction. I'm always reading for a purpose.

(2:56:30 - 2:57:01)

How do I get better at X? How do I learn more about Y? What can I take from this experience that I can then use? Storytelling for dummies. Yeah, right. And if I could have forced myself to read, not poetry, probably, but more fiction, because I think, actually, if you spend most of your life doing what I do, which is reading for purpose, what's the actionable takeaway from what I'm reading? You know about what to do and how to do it.

(2:57:01 - 2:57:19)

You're probably less good at understanding the why. And as Akshita was talking about before, you're less good at understanding people. And what fiction gives you, it's not the actionable takeaway, but it's a much better understanding of people, of humanity, of emotions.

(2:57:20 - 2:57:31)

And of purpose. And of purpose. And it's not poetry, but if I could have made myself read more fiction over time, that would have been a good thing.

(2:57:31 - 2:57:39)

And if I may say, this is the first time I've ever interviewed a couple. Oh, wow. And the loveliest couple that you guys are.

(2:57:39 - 2:57:43)

Oh, you're very sweet. No, that's very kind of you. But we've never done an interview this long, ever.

(2:57:43 - 2:57:46)

And together. Certainly not together. Evil Eye and all that.

(2:57:47 - 2:57:54)

Didn't feel like an interview, though, right? No, not an interview, actually. I'd say a conversation. But more than a conversation, kind of a rumination, no? Yeah.

(2:57:54 - 2:58:45)

And so... We've never done anything like this, actually. We've actually... I'm really intrigued by this point that we all arrived at through that question around, how do you get a 28-year-old who is to get into politics when they're also, rightly, looking for both purpose and validation? And I think, as you said so beautifully, that if you can get someone of that age to engage with just one policy that can impact so many people at such a young age, what is more motivating than that, right? I can tell you... And I learned that Rishi likes poetry, so next birthday gift taken care of. I said fiction, but let's not go too far.

(2:58:45 - 2:58:49)

One step at a time. But thank you, guys, for doing this. This has been great.

(2:58:49 - 2:58:55)

This has been awesome. And great food as well. I'm amazed that we kept eating and talking.

(2:58:55 - 2:59:01)

Yeah, try this one as well. This one is the dark one. Next time you're both in Bangalore, let's do something.

(2:59:01 - 2:59:07)

Yeah, that would be great. We'll be there late this year. And next time we're in Bombay, wouldn't you have to come into the Foundry? Yeah, 100%.

(2:59:07 - 2:59:11)

I will talk about that separately. I know that sounds super exciting. Super exciting.

(2:59:11 - 2:59:18)

It's a three-month course, which is beginning next month. I'd love for you guys to come take a couple of lectures if you guys have time. Yeah, yeah, yeah.

(2:59:19 - 2:59:30)

And if you need... They're all really bright kids. And strangely enough, so many of them are from Stanford and Yale and Wharton. A lot of them have given up college and come back.

(2:59:30 - 2:59:34)

Oh, right. Oh, okay. So they're still at... They're enrolled still.

(2:59:34 - 2:59:37)

Right. I'm so excited. They're taking a quarter off.

(2:59:37 - 2:59:45)

Yeah, yeah, yeah. I'm so excited. And do you know what? I have always fought for the consumer sector.

(2:59:45 - 3:00:19)

This is a great passion. Fundamentally, you and I, I think, are motivated by the same things within the business space, which is consumer behavior. Why? How do people behave? Why do they behave the way they do? Thereby, what kind of actions do they take? What are the market dynamics that influence these actions? And I've always said, yes, unlike B2B companies, unlike SaaS companies, unlike potentially companies in the AI, deep tech space, you don't see outcomes quickly.

(3:00:19 - 3:00:31)

You don't get those same kinds of financial validation quickly. But actually, if you stick at it, some of these companies dramatically change people's lives for the better. Yeah.

(3:00:33 - 3:00:39)

And I think it's fascinating. How often are you going to plan on doing it? Is it once a year? I think once a year. Yeah.

(3:00:39 - 3:00:47)

It'd be tough to do more once a year. Because it is quite intense, right? It's 20 companies that get created, so once a year is good enough. Yeah, it's quite three months.

(3:00:47 - 3:00:55)

Yeah, yeah. It's like one cohort. And do you have one person leading it? And then you have guest lecturers coming in? There's a bunch of people leading it.

(3:00:55 - 3:01:02)

Have you heard of this man called Kishore Biyani? Yes. Yeah, so he's leading it. You know, Ronny Skruvala.

(3:01:02 - 3:01:08)

Yes, I know of him, yeah. They're all living there. Like, I came back early today to do this, but they're all still there.

(3:01:08 - 3:01:10)

Yeah, yeah. Wow. Having a good time.

(3:01:10 - 3:01:29)

I don't know about good time. Last night was 3 a.m. and they needed to really make a decision on some candidates, so there were like these young kids being woken up at 2 a.m. It's really like pushing them beyond the normal. But I'm sure in time they will appreciate that.

(3:01:29 - 3:01:31)

In time. In time. Not today.

(3:01:31 - 3:01:55)

When they're listening, ringing the bell, it will all have been worthwhile. I mean, for a separate conversation, but one of the things I'm thinking about is, because I'm a trustee of the V&A Museum in London, and the V&A, their focus is on creativity. They're called the Museum of Creativity.

(3:01:56 - 3:02:23)

And so what we're thinking is, how do we, how can museums add value to the creative economy? Not just come in and see some old things and marvel, but how can museums add active value and work with the creative economy? So it would be fascinating to have a conversation around that at some point.